

{Sunday}



Hindustan Times

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7 pillars, 1 goal: PM lays out blueprint for 'Viksit Bharat'

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday unveiled seven streams of strength that he said will power the country's journey to Viksit Bharat (developed India) by 2047, announcing mega plans for student coaching classes, civil defence volunteers and urging political parties to back quotas for women in Parliament and state assemblies.

Addressing the nation from the ramparts of the Red Fort to mark the 80th Independence Day, Modi also underlined initiatives to propel innovation among young people and train them in AI, hailed the government's self-reliance strategy amid global energy disruptions, and announced a nationwide talent hunt to identify sportspeople ahead of 2036.

In the 75-minute-long speech, one of his shortest, the PM also warned the country against what he called were dimaagi Naxals (intellectual Naxals). The ceremony was the first when the full six stanzas of the Vande Mataram was played.

Today, from the ramparts of the Red Fort, I invoke seven streams or saptdhara of power coming from the country. In the coming 75 years, what could not be done in the last 57 decades, with the strength and power of saptdhara, we will give the country new heights, new momentum and the ability to achieve new goals," Modi said in Hindi, continued on >7



Prime Minister Narendra Modi greets the audience during the 80th Independence Day celebrations at the Red Fort in Delhi on Saturday.

MODI ANNOUNCES FREE COACHING FOR COMPETITIVE EXAMS

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday announced free online coaching for competitive examinations to reduce the financial burden on poor and middle-class families, and said 10 million youth will be trained in AI over the next year. "Keeping the concerns of poor and middle-class families in mind, we want to help save them the thousands of crores of rupees which they spend on coaching," Modi said.

PM warns of 'dimaagi Naxals'; Oppn hits out

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi sparked a sharp political backlash on Saturday after warning against "dimaagi Naxals" — or intellectual Naxals — during the 80th Independence Day address, drawing criticism from opposition leaders who accused him of using the Red Fort stage to attack political oppo-

nents and intimidate dissenters. Opposition parties condemned the remarks. Congress general secretary Jayaram Ramesh labelled the new terminology a "sure sign of desperation," noting that the prime minister had previously used the phrase "urban Naxals" to target critics.

The 'Saptdhara'

- 1. **MANUFACTURING PROWESS:** Become a reliable global supply-chain hub.
- 2. **AGRICULTURE AND FOOD PROCESSING:** Turn millets, spices and traditional cuisine into global export brands.
- 3. **TECHNOLOGY AND INNOVATION:** Lead in AI, space and robotics.
- 4. **GATI SHAKTI:** Seamless, high-speed connectivity.
- 5. **DEFENCE SHAKTI AND AATMANIRBHAR DEFENCE:** Build self-reliant, next-gen defence and turn exporter.
- 6. **GREEN ECONOMY, BLUE ECONOMY:** Lead in green hydrogen, renewables and deep-sea exploration.
- 7. **SOFT POWER:** Yoga, films, digital content as India's creative strength.

PM PUSHES FOR IMPLEMENTATION OF WOMEN'S QUOTA

PM Narendra Modi urged all political parties to ensure the implementation of 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies "as swiftly as possible." "Today, from the ramparts of the Red Fort, standing under the shadow of the Tricolor, I earnestly appeal to and urge all political parties of our nation: Come forward and celebrate the strength and capability of our women," he said.



BCI CHIEF MISHRA APOLOGISES TO LAW STUDENTS AMID NALSAR ROW

NEW DELHI: A day after CJI Surya Kant came down hard on the Bar Council of India (BCI) for its intervention in the NALSAR University of Law students' protests, BCI chairman Manan Kumar Mishra on Saturday apologised to law students. In an Independence Day letter addressed to "my dear young friends," Mishra said that when students felt aggrieved, their concerns deserved to be heard "with patience, sensitivity and respect".

J'KHAND: STUDENTS SEEK RESIGNATION OF CM, THREATEN TO STEP UP PROTEST

RANCHI: Students protesting against alleged irregularities in the JSC examinations on Saturday said they would gherao Jharkhand chief minister Hemant Soren's official residence on August 20, demanding his resignation. "This is the first time we are making this demand. It's time that accountability for the exams be fixed," said Piyush Singh, spokesperson of the JSC-JSC Reforms March.

Arunachal rains: Workers trapped, armymen missing

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ITANAGAR: Five army personnel were missing, one worker was killed and three were trapped after heavy rains triggered flash floods and landslides in separate districts of Arunachal Pradesh, officials aware of the matter said on Saturday.

In Dibang Valley district, two shelters of the 5th Grenadier at the Pasu Pani Army Camp were washed away by an overflowing stream amid incessant rainfall on Friday evening, according to officials. Superintendent of Police (SP) Pankaj Kumar said seven army personnel were initially caught in the floodwaters. Two of them were rescued later. "SDRF [State Disaster

ARMY PERSONNEL WERE SWEEPED AWAY IN A FLASH FLOOD AND THE WORKERS WERE TRAPPED AFTER A LANDSLIDE IN SEPARATE DISTRICTS

Response Force], NDRF [National Disaster Response Force] and the district DDMO (District Disaster Management Officer) are currently engaged in the search and rescue operation," Kumar said. The names of the missing personnel were not immediately known.

Teams comprising personnel of the 58th Battalion of the Indo-

continued on >7

Chamoli tunnel toll at 8; fate of 2 still unknown

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DEHRADUN: Rescue workers recovered the body of another worker from an inundated tunnel in Chamoli, Uttarakhand, on Saturday, the eighth death after a suspected aquifer burst pushed a rush of water and debris through the under-construction passage earlier this week.

The search for two more workers missing since the accident was still underway but hampered by precarious conditions, said officials involved in the rescue at the Tehri Hydro Development Corporation (THDC) tunnel. Twenty-two workers were on shift when the incident occurred around 7pm on Thursday. Of them, eight have been declared dead and 12 are in hospital with injuries.

Officials said work is on to drain the inundated tunnel. Chamoli district magistrate Gaurav Kumar said, "Suction pumps and other equipment are being used to facilitate the movement of rescue personnel inside the tunnel and help them reach areas where the missing workers may be trapped."

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TRUMP SAYS WILL DECLARE HORMUZ 'U.S. TERRITORY'; IRAN HITS BACK

NEW YORK: Iran on Saturday fired back at US President Donald Trump's claim that he would soon declare the Strait of Hormuz part of US territory, saying the crucial energy waterway it has blockaded "will remain Iranian." Trump has repeatedly said the strait, which Tehran effectively closed at the start of the West Asia war in late February, is under US control — an assertion the Islamic republic denies. The Strait of Hormuz has been Iranian, is Iranian, and will remain Iranian," Iranian deputy foreign minister Karim Gharibabadi said on X.

FOREIGN ASSET DISCLOSURE PLAN LAUNCHED FOR SMALL TAXPAYERS

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NEW DELHI: Eligible small taxpayers, including young professionals and tech employees, can avail of a one-time amnesty to disclose undisclosed foreign assets and regularise their foreign income by December 31, according to a finance ministry notification.

Under the scheme, taxpayers will have to pay 30% of the market value of their assets as tax and an additional 30% in lieu of penalty. The notification gives effect to the budget announcement made by Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on February 1.

7.7-intensity earthquake strikes off Indonesia's coast killing 47

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MAUMERE: A powerful magnitude 7.7 earthquake struck off the coast of Indonesia early Saturday, killing at least 47 people, causing widespread destruction in the region. Authorities said dozens more residents were injured and warned that the death toll would almost certainly rise.

Authorities issued a tsunami warning and urged coastal residents to move to higher ground, but later lifted the warning when Indonesia's meteorological agency said monitoring showed no significant sea-level changes that posed a threat to coastal communities.



A wrecked house in Ruteng village, Indonesia on Sunday.

Some smaller tsunamis were reported. The US Geological Survey said the quake hit eastern Indonesia's Flores region at a depth of 10km at 5.58am local time.

Some remote villages were completely isolated and damaged infrastructure and a lack of heavy equipment were hindering rescue and relief efforts, said officials.

Here's to the ones who dream

Could India be where some of the world's best new ideas come from? In an Independence Day special, Kashyap Kompella argues that the answers to some of our most audacious questions are already here

SAKET BUILDING COLLAPSE: OWNER, BUILDERS NAMED IN CHARGE SHEET

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police have filed a charge sheet against three people for their role in the building collapse in Saket, Delhi, that killed six people, officers said on Saturday. The charge sheet was filed against Karanvir Singh (the owner of the building), Avinash Gupta, dilapidated buildings, heritage conservation, landscaping, traffic and transport, pedestrian walkways, parking, and recreational and cultural spaces. Local bodies, it adds, may pre-

continued on >7

{ COMMERCIAL, RESIDENTIAL HUB }

Karol Bagh in focus, set for widespread revamp

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NEW DELHI: The Master Plan for Delhi-2047 has proposed an integrated improvement framework for Karol Bagh's 2,300-hectare Special Area — the third such vision document for the district in as many Master Plans, after MPD-2001 and MPD-2012, flagged similar objectives with little on the ground to show for them.

Karol Bagh is one of Delhi's hardest planning problems. A pre-Partition planned extension that became a refuge for resettlement hub after 1947, its narrow lanes today carry some of the city's oldest and busiest markets — Ajmal Khan Road, Ghaffar Market, Bank

Street — alongside a dense residential population squeezed by decades of unregulated commercial expansion. MPD-2047 notes Karol Bagh's mix of plotted residential and commercial areas and proposes that an "integrated improvement plan shall be prepared" — one

that would identify stretches where the plotted character must be protected and those where regeneration can be permitted. The improvement, the draft says, should cover urban design, dilapidated buildings, heritage conservation, landscaping, traffic and transport, pedestrian walkways, parking, and recreational and cultural spaces. Local bodies, it adds, may pre-

continued on >7

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Hon'ble Vice President of India
will be the Chief Guest and deliver the Convocation Address

Thiru. Rajendra Vishwanath Arjekar
Hon'ble Governor of Kerala and Hon'ble Governor of Tamil Nadu
will be the Guest of Honour

Dr. T. R. Paavirivendhar
Founder, Chancellor, SRM Institute of Science and Technology
will preside over the Convocation

Shri R. Velusamy
President - Automotive Business, Mahindra & Mahindra Limited
will be conferred with the Honorary Degree of Doctor of Science (D.Sc.)

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{ 80TH INDEPENDENCE DAY CELEBRATION }

People's welfare is highest priority: Vijay

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Saving people from corruption is equivalent to achieving a massive liberation, and his government has been working towards that goal since it assumed office. Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay said on Saturday.

After unfurling the tricolour at Fort St. George during the 80th Independence Day celebrations, Vijay said, "we are operating as a transparent, truthful and honest administration."

"There should be no compromise in public life. People's welfare is the absolute highest priority. Whether it is policy decisions against Tamil Nadu, our Tamillaga Vettri Kazhagam government will always oppose them. There is no second opinion about that," he said in his first Independence Day address as chief minister.

The ruling Tamillaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) emerged victorious in the April 23 Assembly polls and formed the government with the support of Congress, Viduthalaithirukatchi, Indian Union Muslim League and the Left parties. Thanking people for electing him, Vijay said, "I salute the people of Tamil Nadu who broke caste and religion conditioning, rejecting money and muscle power and gave us an overwhelming support to establish the people-centric and social justice government. 'We are on a mission mode to achieve a corruption-free government and want our people to develop zero tolerance towards corruption. We seek an appeal to our officials and the people of the state to make it corruption-free,' he said.

Guided by the principle of 'all are equal' (Prapokum ella uyirukum), Vijay said his government was working to



Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay inspects the Guard of Honour at the 80th Independence Day celebrations at Fort St. George in Chennai on Saturday (left); Andhra Pradesh CM N Chandrababu Naidu and two senior police officers salute the tricolour after it is unfurled during the celebrations at the state's capital Amaravati.

build a Tamil Nadu free of bribery, corruption and substance abuse, with a focus on women's safety and social justice.

"On the same basis, we are implementing people-centric welfare schemes while maintaining administrative cooperation with the Central Government," he said.

Vijay said his government will increase the number of Amma Unavagam scheme introduced by former chief minister J Jayalalithaa. The breakfast scheme, he said, would also be expanded from Class 6 to Class 8 from September 15.

He said government offices and police stations had been transformed into public service centres and directed officials to treat citizens approaching them with "utmost dignity and kindness."

"People should not be made to run around, and their requests must be properly examined to deliver appropriate solutions," he said.

Appealing to people to stand by his government, Vijay said,

"The Chief Minister post represents 8 crore people. That is why I say: the people are the real rulers here. Me and everyone here, as well as over there (MLAs and government officials) are merely servants of the people. That is how I view it."

Vijay announced several measures for ex-servicemen, freedom fighters and their families.

Marriage assistance for the two daughters of ex-servicemen will be increased from ₹25,000 to ₹50,000. Monthly financial assistance for differently-abled ex-servicemen and their dependents will rise from ₹5,000 to ₹7,000.

The state's monthly pension for freedom fighters will be increased to ₹23,000, while the family pension will rise to ₹12,500.

The monthly special pension for the legal heirs of historical leaders, including descendants of Veerapandiya Kattabomman, Muthuramalinga Raghunatha Sethupathi and the Marudhu Brothers, will be increased to ₹11,500.

Vijay also presented the "Thagnasail Thammizhar Award" to former Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president M Krishnasamy.

The award carries a cash prize of ₹10 lakh and a citation and honours eminent personalities for their contribution to the welfare of Tamil Nadu and development of the Tamil fraternity.

Diabetologist Dr V Mohan received the Dr APJ Abdul Kalam Award for his contribution to diabetes research. His daughter M Anjana, managing director of Dr Mohan's Diabetes Specialities Centre, Chennai, received the award on his behalf.

Coin-toss-based Naushen Bannu received the Kalpana Chawla Award for courage and enterprise after becoming the first woman to run the world's highest-altitude marathon at Mount Everest.

Vijay later posed for a group photograph with the award winners along with chief secretary M Sai Kumar and others at the Sati Sarai.

'From destruction to development': Naidu lists govt's 26-month tenure

Srinivasa Rao Apparao

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HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh's Amaravati on Saturday witnessed its first official Independence Day celebrations in the state's history. Chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu hoisted the tricolour and urged people onward to a collective commitment to build a "Swarna Andhra 2047" in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "Viksit Bharat 2047" vision.

Addressing a rally after hoisting the tricolour, Naidu urged people to embrace the principle of "My country, my responsibility."

Highlighting his government's 26-month tenure, Naidu claimed that Andhra Pradesh had moved from "destruction to development" and from "crisis to stability." He said the government had spent ₹150 lakh crore on welfare

and ₹134 lakh crore on development, while restructuring ₹70 loans to save ₹8,269 crore in interest.

He added that the state revived 96 centrally sponsored schemes discontinued by the previous regime. He highlighted welfare initiatives such as enhanced pensions, Thaliki Vandanam, free bus travel for women under Stree Shakti, free LPG cylinders under Deepam-2 and Anna Canteens.

"My government is targeting poverty-free society, employment generation, skill development, water security, agri-tech, logistics, clean energy, quality products and deep technology under the 10-point Swarna Andhra 2047 vision," he said.

On investments and jobs, Naidu said pacts were signed for ₹24 lakh crore in investments, of which ₹14 lakh crore had already been approved, with the poten-

tial to generate around 1,100,000 jobs.

Social justice our priority: Revanth

Telangana chief minister A Revanth Reddy asserted that his government was striving to incorporate all sections of society into their welfare and development agenda.

On the state's economic performance, Revanth said Telangana's per capita income had reached ₹4,18,931 in 2025-26, nearly 9% higher than the national average. "Telangana had also surpassed Punjab to become the country's No.1 state in paddy cultivation area and production," he claimed.

The chief minister reiterated the government's commitment to social justice, citing the caste survey and its legislation seeking 42% reservations for BCs in education, employment and politics.

This is the time to analyse problems with utmost precision, look into the future, embrace the new generation, and step forward with care

VD SATHEESAN, Kerala CM

Let's work towards making the country and the state No.1 by 2047... 80 years ago we procured our independence and now let's work towards winning the world

N CHANDRABABU NAIDU, Andhra Pradesh CM

Shaping tomorrow with knowledge and energy, let's move forward together with the values of equality, brotherhood, progress and humanity!

MK STALIN, Former TN CM

DKS unveils AI, coding programmes for schools

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar on Saturday announced the AI Akshara Abhiyana and Coding Gurukula programme to introduce artificial intelligence education in schools across the state and equip students to compete at the global level.

"We are now entering a new technological era. The AI campaign and Coding Gurukula - this is your era, a new era," Shivakumar said in his Independence Day speech from the sprawling Field Marshal Sam Manekshaw Parade Ground.

He explained that AI education would be introduced in all schools from Class 6, and added his government was working to establish India's first government-owned AI university in Bengaluru.

Stressing on the need to improve the quality of schools and colleges, the CM said an expert committee constituted to reform the examination system would submit its report within two months.

Outlining his vision for Karnataka, Shivakumar said "Youth Karnataka, New India" was his

government's slogan and said the state had set a target of taking its economy to USD three trillion, or ₹320 lakh crore, by 2047.

Minister Khan skips flag-hoisting event

Expelled BJP MLA Basanagouda Patil Yatal on Saturday called for action against state minister Zameer Ahmed Khan after he skipped a flag-hoisting ceremony in Vijayanagara district.

Speaking in Vijayanagara city, Yatal said every citizen and public representative should respect the national anthem and the national flag.

"However, minister Zameer Ahmed has insulted them," Yatal alleged. He claimed that despite the CM's directions that Zameer Ahmed was expected to perform the flag-hoisting ceremony in Vijayanagara district, Khan wrote a letter stating that he would not be able to attend the programme.

State health minister UT Khader defended Khan. If he has some emergency issues there, he would not be able to attend the programme. He also hit out at critics who had written, "he said, adding that Khan's 'patriotism cannot be questioned."



(Clockwise from top-left) Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar waves during the India Parade in Bengaluru; A street performer at the parade near Vidhana Soudha; a female police officer takes part in the parade; and an elderly woman waves a tricolour on Saturday.



Row erupts as 3 'poachers' shot dead in K'taka

Yohan P Honadi and Coovercolly Indresh

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BIDAR/BENGALURU: Forest officials shot dead three suspected poachers in Chamara Nagar district's Holadoti forest early on Saturday, police said. Chief minister DK Shivakumar said that the state government has ordered a magisterial enquiry into the deaths, and a separate police probe is also underway.

The deceased were identified as Peter, Kumar and Antonywamy, whose wife Lourdamany lodged a complaint upon which an FIR was registered. She said that her family reared cattle to earn a living, and Antonywamy, his brother Kumar, brother-in-law Peter and another relative Joseph entered the forest on Tuesday to search for cattle that were reportedly missing. The group stayed the night in the forest, she added.

Forest officials said the firing incident occurred early on Saturday, they claimed, and responded to a tip-off to find the three men cutting meat out of a wild animal's carcass and tried to take them into custody before they allegedly opened fire and officials were forced to respond in kind, killing three of the group on the spot. Officials also claimed that a member of the group was also injured in the firing.

The group's lone survivor, Joseph, as well as other family members, strongly denied the department's allegations. The deceased men's nephew Vijay Anthony told reporters that the family would resort to accept the bodies till steps were taken to ensure action against

forest personnel through an impartial probe.

"They were ordinary farmers who cultivated land and reared cows and buffaloes. When our cattle go into the forest to graze and do not return home even after nightfall, it is normal for us to go looking for them... Even if they had weapons, was there a need to shoot them in a way that took their lives? The department employee was hit by a bullet," he said.

Speaking to reporters in Bengaluru, CM Shivakumar said, "I received all the information today at around 5 am about the forest department personnel conducting an encounter with those who had gone to hunt animals. We have ordered a magisterial enquiry. The facts will come out."

He added that certain documents and other material, including weapons, were seized in connection with the incident. Forest officials claimed they recovered a country-made firearm and a deer carcass from the men.

Expressing outrage, state president of the Karnataka Rakshana Vedike (KR) Praveen Shetty said it is unfortunate that even 80 years after independence, farmers are still not getting justice.



Nainar Nagenthiran

BJP TN Chief faces backlash over remarks against Vijay

CHENNAI: Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) Tamil Nadu unit chief Nainar Nagenthiran on Saturday came under attack over alleged derogatory remarks against chief minister C Joseph Vijay and his family.

The Tamillaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), Congress, former Tamil Nadu BJP chief K Annamalai all slammed Nagenthiran for his remarks and demanded an "unconditional apology" from him.

Speaking at a party event at Kamalayam, the BJP state headquarters, Nagenthiran mockingly remarked, "When people search for a father in the house and cannot find him, they should ask the mother at home to know who the father is." The remarks sparked widespread backlash, with several leaders condemning them as derogatory and disrespectful.

Officials said a TVK worker has filed a complaint with the District Collector's Office. Reacting sharply, state school education minister A Rajmohan referred to Nagenthiran's comments as "uncivilised speech, slanderous and disrespectful."

Annamalai called the comments "highly condemnable." State Congress chief B Manikam Tagore also objected to the comments.

"Sweeping low with politically uncivilised remarks is not a first for him. It has become a recurring habit (for Nagenthiran)," he alleged.

In a post on X, Nagenthiran said his remarks were not intended to target anyone.

"During the book release event of Oru Naadu 2.0, those who seek to twist and misrepresent the speech I delivered on stage for political gain—I wish to inform them that I did not speak targeting anyone with any ulterior motive," Nagenthiran said.

"I am one who holds immense concern for the mother, for the motherland, and for the mother tongue," he added.

T'gana launches smart ration cards to aid PDS beneficiaries

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HYDERABAD: Telangana chief minister A Revanth Reddy said on Saturday that the state government is introducing new smart ration cards, targeting 10.5 million eligible families across the state.

The credit-card-sized PVC smart ration cards are compact, durable, waterproof tear-resistant smart cards, featuring an encrypted QR code alongside next-generation security elements to prevent duplication.

The new cards display the cardholder's name, address and photograph, with a QR code providing access to details of family members and transaction history of commodities such as rice, sugar and wheat.



using an OTP and create an M-PIN, state civil supplies minister N Uttam Kumar Reddy said.

Launching the cards at a public meeting in Sangareddy, Revanth Reddy said the card was not merely a document enabling people to procure rice but represented of poor families' self-respect and dignity.

"Wherever they go, they have the assurance that their hunger can be addressed," the chief minister said.

Inspiration from former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi in implementing welfare programmes for the poor.

Stating that his government was supplying fine quality rice to the poor families through the public distribution system, claimed that the decision of the government to distribute fine rice through ration shops had also contributed to a drop in rice prices in the open market.

Revanth Reddy alleged that the opposition BRS and BJP had never over thought of supplying quality rice to the consumers. He also hit out at critics who had predicted that power supply would deteriorate if the Congress came to power. "They said that if Congress came to power, there would be no electricity. Did the power supply stop anywhere?" he asked.

Civil supplies minister Uttam Kumar Reddy said since January 26, 2025, the state has issued 16,32,840 new Food Security Cards. These cards cover 6,08,544 beneficiaries.

Kerala man with drug abuse history stabs parents to death, arrested in Idukki: Police

IDAUKKI: A 29-year-old man allegedly stabbed his parents to death in Idukki district, police said on Saturday.

Police arrested Ajeesh after he allegedly killed his father Antony, 59, and mother Valsamma, 55, at their residence at Ezhukumayal around 9.30 pm on Friday.

Police said Ajeesh, who had a history of alcohol and drug use, had undergone a de-addiction programme.

After returning from the de-addiction centre, he regularly quarrelled with his parents, police said.

IAS officer D Sajith Babu appointed new Kerala CEO: Officials

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM:

IAS officer D Sajith Babu has been appointed as the new CEO of Kerala after the EC approved his appointment, officials said on Saturday.

The Office of the Kerala Chief Electoral Officer announced the appointment on the appointment on its Facebook page. "Election Commission of India approved the name of D Sajith Babu for the appointment as Chief Electoral Officer, Kerala," the statement said.

Man kills wife, dies by suicide, probe underway: Cops

BENGALURU: A man has allegedly murdered his wife before dying by suicide at their residence in Bengaluru, police said on Saturday. Police said that the couple may have had an argument that later turned violent and a probe was underway. Officers said that the exact cause of death would be clear only after the post-mortem examination was complete. The deceased worked as a civil and a software engineer, they said.

SPOTLIGHT INDEPENDENCE DAY



Prime Minister Narendra Modi inspects the guard of honour during the Independence Day celebrations at the Red Fort on Saturday.

ARVIND YADAV/HT

PM pushes for women's quota implementation

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday urged all political parties to come forward to ensure 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, "as swiftly as possible", making a renewed pitch to pass the Constitution amendment bill to roll out the women's quota in 2029 Lok Sabha election.

Addressing the nation from the ramparts of the Red Fort, PM Modi said, "My dear fellow citizens, today in panchayats, municipalities and municipal corporations, our women public representatives are guiding the nation in very large numbers, solving local challenges and providing exceptionally capable and empowering leadership. Keeping this in mind, we passed the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhinyam unanimously—but the Modi government's double standards and hypocrisy ensured that it could not be implemented until the 2024 elections. This Act was notified in haste and quietly on the evening of April 16, 2026," he said.

"The Prime Minister should remember that the provision for women's reservation was introduced into the Constitution through the 73rd and 74th Amendments passed in 1993, and the vision and firm resolve behind realising it belonged to Shri Bhaiji Gandhi. @INCIndia has consistently stood firm on its position to implement women's reservation within the current number of Lok Sabhas starting from the 2029 Lok Sabha elections," Ramesh added.

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav said the Red Fort is not the place from where one should speak lies, and urged the Centre to implement the Women Reservation Bill in the 2027 UP Assembly elections.

Titanmool Congress lawmaker Sakarika Ghose claimed that the PM is again appealing to the opposition for 33% women's reservation in Parliament when the law has been passed. "Dear Mr Modi, the law has been passed, please bring women's reservation TODAY, NOW, implement 33% reservation for women in the 543 member House NOW, IMMEDIATELY. Why aren't you doing it? Because what you actually want is NOT representation for women, but Delimitation to massively bolster seats in north India so you can INCREASE your seat tally. You are SINGING women's reservation for an out and out political agenda," Ghose said.

To be sure, Parliament had passed the women reservation bill or Nari Shakti Vandan Adhinyam in 2023, which proposed to roll out women reservation from 2034 on the basis of the ongoing census data.

The government, however, wants to pass a new bill to implement reservation from the 2029 Lok Sabha poll on the basis of 2011 census and it would block 272 seats for women in an expanded Lok Sabha that would constitute of 815 seats. Union law minister Arjun Ram Meghwal had introduced The Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill for this purpose during a special session in April this year. It fell short of two-third majority

in the revised sequence of the ceremony, the national song was rendered before the flag hoisting and Modi's address from the historic Red Fort for the 13th consecutive year. "Today, every heart is resounding with the chant of national song, 'Vande Mataram'. Today the tricolour is in every heart," the Prime Minister said.

Key goals on India's road to 2047

Prime Minister Narendra Modi outlined an ambitious national roadmap aimed at transforming India into a fully developed nation by 2047, setting targets for:

- Made-in-India 66 to reach every corner of the world**
"We have demonstrated our capabilities and established our credentials through UPI and Digital Public Infrastructure."
- 50 Indian companies among the Fortune 500 within the next decade**
"Every citizen is a part of the nation. Why can we not aspire to have 50 Indian companies among the Fortune 500 within the next decade?"
- An Indian bank among the world's top five banks**
"Today, the banking sector is flourishing. Why should the flag of an Indian bank not fly among world's top banks?"
- Placing Indian pharma companies among the world's top five**
"The need of the hour is for one or two Indian pharmaceutical firms to make their mark among the world's top 5 pharma companies."
- Bringing 2036 Olympics to India**
"Bharat is also set to host the Commonwealth Games in 2030... We want the 2036 Olympics to be held in Bharat too."
- Development of port-led growth**
"We must take our ports forward in the direction of port-led development and growth."
- Making Nasha Mukta Bharat a collective responsibility**
"...drug addiction is becoming a major challenge, a Drug-Free India (Nasha Mukta Bharat) should be a collective responsibility for all of us."

Cong targets Modi over 'wrong policies'

Saahubhadr Chatterji
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NEW DELHI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Saturday accused PM Narendra Modi-led government of crushing the dreams of the youth, avoiding questions in Parliament and pushing young people towards protests through its policies.

Speaking at Indira Bhawan after Modi's Independence Day address, Kharge said peaceful protest was a constitutional right and students demanding their rights should not be branded anti-national.

"The government's wrong policies have pushed the youth into a dark road," Kharge said, adding that the government had "neither the funds nor the ideas for schemes that drive the nation forward."

He also questioned why Modi and Union Minister Amit Shah did not respond to Opposition concerns over police action against students during protests at Delhi's Jantar Mantar.

"And the Leader of the Opposition, Rahul Gandhi, have been continuously raising questions about the brutality inflicted on students and youth, but the Prime Minister and the House Speaker have not come to the House. On top of that, Amit Shah says that



Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge and Sonia Gandhi during Independence Day celebrations at the AICC headquarters.

Parliament was not in session, so I did not come to the House, but I was sitting in my chamber and watching and listening to everything. The question is Did the public send you to sit in your chamber?" Kharge said. He also accused the BJP of taking credit for work done during previous Congress governments.

"The development you see in the country today is because of Congress. Congress has 90% contribution in development you witnessed in the country today. We improved people's financial condition, not change names. But, these people just take credit. This will

not go on for long," Kharge said. "We brought Right to Food, Right to Education, Right to Work but the current government has not done any such work. Yet some people have the habit of taking credit for the work they have not done. The history records everything," he added.

Kharge also raised the issue of alleged theft of offerings at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, questioning the government's handling of the matter and pointing out that the temple trust had been appointed by the Prime Minister. He also alleged interference by the government in key institutions,

including the Election Commission, Enforcement Directorate, CBI and the media, and claimed that people aligned with the RSS were being appointed to several educational institutions as well as organisations such as ISRO and DRDO. Meanwhile, the BJP on Saturday accused Congress leader Sonia Gandhi of objecting to the singing of the full version of Vande Mataram at the party's Independence Day event. However, the Congress denied the charge, asserting that there was no attempt to stop the singing of the full version of the national song and Gandhi was only asking for a chair for party chief Mallikarjun Kharge as he was standing for a while.

Sharing video footage on X, BJP national general secretary (organisation) B L Santhosh said, "Mother, son and national president (of the Congress) seem to be upset by the rendering of full Vande Mataram." Certain mindsets never change from pre-1947 to post-1947, the senior BJP leader added.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh categorically denied that there was an attempt to stop the singing of the song's full version. "As the Congress president was standing for a long time, Soniji was asking for a chair for him," he said.

Addressing the nation on the 80th Independence Day, Modi said India needed to prepare citizens for new-age threats, including attacks on refineries, banks, data centres and vital installations.

"Today, the nature of war is changing. There is no guarantee that war happens only at the border. Today, war can happen inside the country. They can target a refinery, a bank, the defence sector or data centre. A new form of warfare is emerging against infrastructure. ...but at the same time, we will have to prepare the citizens."

"I announce today that we will build a vibrant Civil Defence network in the coming days. We will familiarise them with modern systems. What measures can protect citizens from modern-day challenges? We are going to create a large modern Civil Defence volunteer force capable of overcoming contemporary challenges," he said.

Modi said the existing civil defence system, developed for conventional wars, needed to be updated to meet contemporary challenges. "Making India safe is the responsibility of all of us. Whether the challenge is within the borders or outside the borders, India is prepared for every situation," he said.

The civil defence network was put to a major test during Operation Abhyas in May 2025, when the government conducted nationwide exercises amid heightened tensions following the Pahalgam terror attack. The exercise covered 40 districts and included air-raid warnings systems, blackout measures, evacuation drills and protection of vital installations.

Row erupts as Modi warns against threat of 'dimaagi Naxals'

HT Correspondents
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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Saturday that while armed Naxalite violence in India is on the verge of elimination, a subtle threat of "dimaagi Naxals"—or intellectual Naxals—is actively attempting to incite anarchy and mislead the nation's youth.

Delivering the 80th Independence Day address from the ramparts of the Red Fort, Modi said that while security forces have successfully dismantled armed Maoist insurgencies in the forests, individuals carrying an ideological Naxal mind are quietly seeking opportunities to drag society down the wrong path.

Modi cautioned that Maoist ideology had historically embedded itself in the corridors of power and advisory committees, influencing government policies for decades.

"We must isolate these dimaagi (intellectual) Naxals and connect the country's young generation to the mainstream of transforming our nation into a developed nation."

The Prime Minister's remarks drew swift and fierce condemnation from opposition parties, who accused Modi of using the Independence Day to attack political opponents, stigmatise legitimate dissent, and intimidate critics.

Congress General Secretary Jairam Ramesh labelled the new terminology a "sure sign of desperation," noting Modi's evolving rhetoric against his critics.

"First he called his opponents 'urban naxals'. Now he calls them 'dimaagi Naxals'. It is a sure sign of his desperation," Ramesh pointed out, saying that the prime minister frequently ends up adopting policies advocated by those he criticises.

"To the baseless categories repeatedly conjured up by the Right Wing anti-national, 'tukade' and others, Modi has now added another absurd label: 'dimaagi Naxal'. This is nothing but an attempt to stigmatise dissent and intimidate those who question the government."

Titanmool Congress MP Mahua Moitra sarcastically embraced the label, posting, "I am a dimaagi Naxal. All cockroaches by definition are."

work in the coming days. We will familiarise them with modern systems. What measures can protect citizens from modern-day challenges? We are going to create a large modern Civil Defence volunteer force capable of overcoming contemporary challenges," he said.

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Vande Mataram recited in full

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NEW DELHI: All six main stanzas of Vande Mataram were rendered for the first time during the 80th Independence Day celebrations at the Red Fort, days after a legislation elevating it to the same status as the national anthem was passed. The Union government made the rendition of all six stanzas of the national song mandatory this year amid the 150th-year Vande Mataram celebrations. It ended the decades-old practice of singing its first two stanzas that were adopted as the national song in 1950.

Today, on 15th August, for the first time, Vande Mataram is echoing at the Red Fort. Today, as we, the people of the country, celebrate 150 years of Vande Mataram, what could be a better opportunity than this? PM Narendra Modi said while addressing the nation from the ramparts of Red Fort.



Union ministers Nirmala Sitharaman, S Jaishankar and others stand for Vande Mataram at the Red Fort.

At Home reception



President Droupadi Murmu, Vice President CP Radhakrishnan, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla at the At Home Reception hosted at Rashtrapati Bhavan on Independence Day on Saturday. The annual Independence Day reception is a formal gathering hosted by the President and brings together individuals making notable contributions to public service, defence, sports, cinema, arts and other fields.

VANDE MATARAM ROW ERUPTS AT KERALA CIVIC BODY

KOZHIKODE: A row erupted at Kozhikode Corporation office on Saturday when 13 BJP councillors sang Vande Mataram while LDF and UDF councillors sang Jana Gana Mana during Independence Day celebrations.

BJP councillors alleged Mayor and Deputy Mayor belittled Vande Mataram, saying, "When we started singing Vande Mataram, they started singing the national anthem."

Mayor O Sadanar said Vande Mataram was not on the agenda and BJP councillors had not sought permission. "Reciting Vande Mataram was not part of the agenda at all," he said. However, none of the other councillors present at the event had prevented the BJP councillors from singing Vande Mataram, Mayor O Sadanar said.

PM announces free online coaching for competitive exams

Sanjay Maurya

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday announced free online coaching for competitive examinations to reduce the financial burden on poor and middle-class families, and said 10 million youth will be trained in artificial intelligence (AI) over the next year.

Addressing the nation from the ramparts of the Red Fort on Independence Day, Modi said the government would create a network by bringing together digital public infrastructure, teachers and educators to provide free coaching to students preparing for various examinations. "The competition surrounding coaching classes has become a huge burden for middle-class families. Every parent feels that if they do not send their children to a coaching centre, they are somehow falling behind or do not belong to a respectable family. Keeping the concerns of poor and middle-class families in mind, we want to help save them the thousands of crores of rupees which they spend on coaching," he said.

"Our young people should be able to stay close to their families, receive their care, and avoid placing an additional financial burden on them," he added.

Therefore, we have decided to provide free online coaching for various competitive examinations for our youth. We have digital public infrastructure, and we have highly talented teachers and educators. By bringing these resources together, we will provide free coaching to the country's young people and build an entire network for this purpose.

The announcement comes weeks after youth-led protests over issues including the NEET-UG paper leak and examination reforms were held in several parts of the country last month. The "Sanskrit Chalo" (march to Parliament) campaign on July 20 brought students' concerns over examinations and the coaching



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with school children after his 80th Independence Day speech from the Red Fort. RAI RAJAT PHOTO

system into focus. The agitation eventually led to the resignation of then Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan on July 25. The Centre has already taken steps towards providing free online academic assistance. IIT Kanpur runs SATHEE (Self-Assessment Test and Help for Entrance Exams), an online education platform launched in November 2023 in collaboration with the department of higher education under the Union education ministry. SATHEE provides free educational content and guidance for competitive examinations including JEE, NEET, CUET, ICAR, SSC and IBPS. More than 21 lakh learners have registered on the platform so far, Union education minister Pralhad Joshi told the Lok Sabha on August 3.

In June 2025, the education ministry had also set up a nine-member expert committee to recommend reforms to reduce students' dependence on private coaching centres and curb the growth of parallel "dummy schools". The committee has held three meetings and is yet to submit its recommendations.

Modi also announced that the government will provide AI skill training to 10 million youth in the next year, saying young people would play a central role in building a developed India.

"My dear fellow citizens, when I

speak of a Viksit Bharat, when I speak of advancing the nation at high speed—who is the greatest beneficiary of this? Who is the greatest driving force behind all these efforts? It is the driving force, it is the youth of my country. It is the power of my nation's youth," Modi said.

"Today, from the ramparts of the Red Fort, I wish to make an announcement for the youth of the country. We have resolved that in the coming one year, we will work to provide AI skill training to 10 million youth, so that the youth of our nation possess the capability to lead the world in the domain of AI as well," he added.

The Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship launched the Skill for All Readiness (SOAR) programme in July 2025 to build basic AI skills among school students in Classes 6 to 12 and educators. The programme includes courses on AI basics, generative AI, programming, ethics, cybersecurity and career opportunities. As of March 2026, around 230,000 learners had enrolled in the programme, of whom nearly 28,800 had been certified, HT had reported earlier.

Hailing the country's youth, Modi said they would be both the driving force and the biggest beneficiaries of a developed India. He had to link the goal of a developed India with our youth...

PM's headdresses over the years



Since 2014, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has made it a tradition to wear distinctive traditional Indian headdress during his Independence Day speeches from the Red Fort. Each year features different styles of turbans and safas showcasing India's rich textile heritage, including vibrant colours, regional patterns, and traditional designs that reflect the country's cultural diversity. PTI

World leaders extend wishes

"I am confident that, through our joint efforts, we will continue to comprehensively strengthen the constructive Russia-India partnership..."

—RUSSIAN PRESIDENT
VLADIMIR PUTIN

"Congratulations to the Indian people on your 80th Independence Day!"

—FRENCH PRESIDENT
EMMANUEL
MACRON

"May we continue to strengthen the beautiful friendship between Israel and India"

—ISRAELI PRESIDENT
ISRAAC HERZOG

"I join you in celebrating India's history and culture, rich diversity and extraordinary achievements - and in celebrating the promise our shared future holds"

—AUSTRALIAN
PRIME
MINISTER
ANTHONY
ALBANESE

"Eight decades of Independence reflect the aspirations, resilience and enduring spirit of the Government and people of India"

—MALDIVIAN PRESIDENT
MOHAMED MUIZZU



People's welfare is the highest priority: Vijay

S Vijay Karthik

letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: Saving people from corruption is equivalent to achieving a massive liberation, and his government has been working towards that goal since it assumed office, Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay said on Saturday.

After unfurling the tricolour at Fort St George during the 80th Independence Day celebrations, Vijay said, "we are operating as a transparent, truthful and honest administration."

"There should be no compromise in public life. People's welfare is the absolute highest priority. Whether it is policy decisions against Tamil Nadu, our Tamilara Vettai Kazhagam (TVK) government will always oppose them. There is no second opinion about that," he said in his maiden Independence Day address.

The ruling TVK emerged victorious in the April 23 assembly polls and formed the government with the support of Congress, Vidadhalaithi Chiruthaigal Katchi, Indian Union Muslim League and Left parties.

Thanking people for electing him, Vijay said, "I salute the people of Tamil Nadu who broke caste and religion considerations, rejecting money and muscle power and gave us an overwhelming support



C. Joseph Vijay at Fort St. George in Chennai on Saturday. PTI

to establish the people-centric and social justice government."

Guided by the principle of "all are born equal," Vijay said his government was working to build a Tamil Nadu free of bribery, corruption and substance abuse, with a focus on women's safety and social justice. Vijay said his government was refining and continuing the Anna Unavagam scheme introduced by ex-CM J Jayalalithaa. The breakfast scheme, he said, would also be expanded from Class 6 to Class 8 from September 15.

Vijay said, "The chief minister post represents 8 crore people. The real rulers here. Me and every one here, as well as over there (MLAs and government officials) are merely servants of the people. That is how I view it."

He announced several measures for ex-servicemen, freedom fighters and their families. Marriage assistance for the two daughters of ex-servicemen will be increased from ₹25,000 to ₹50,000. Monthly assistance for differently-abled ex-servicemen and dependents will rise from ₹5,000 to ₹7,000. Monthly pension for freedom fighters will be increased to ₹23,000 while family pension will rise to ₹12,500.

Meanwhile, BJP Tamil Nadu chief Nainar Nagenanthran's remarks targeting Vijay sparked a political row on Saturday.

Speaking at a party event at the BJP headquarters in Chennai, Nagenanthran said, "When people search for a father in the house and cannot find him, they should ask the mother at home to know who the father is."

Minister A Rajmohan called them "uncivilised and inappropriate".

Former BJP president K Annamalai also slammed Nagenanthran for the remark, saying that he had crossed political decorum, terming personal attacks on a leader's family, particularly their mother, unacceptable. He described such remarks as regressive, "third-rate" politics that should not be encouraged among the younger generation.

With PTI inputs

LEADERS ON I-DAY

Where once guns roared, now patriotism echoes. The Tricolour waving over the red soil is a symbol of strength, progress and self-confidence of a Naxal-free new Bastar

AMIT SHAH,
Home minister

If our situation had not been altered in 2019, the people of that part of J&K across LoC would have been protesting to reunite with us

OMAR
ABDULLAH,
J&K CM

I want to assure every student... their hard work will not be left at the mercy of any mafia, corrupt system, or irregularity

HEMANT SOREN,
Jharkhand CM

Freedom does not merely mean political freedom. It means complete liberation...

YOGI
ADITYANATH,
UP CM

PM highlights green, blue economy vision in speech

Jasjeev Gandhi

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday listed a Green and Blue economy among the country's seven sapthadharas (seven streams of strength), and scoring the vision for India to become a global leader in green hydrogen, renewable energy generation and storage, and deep-sea exploration.

Modi, in his Independence Day speech from Delhi's Red Fort, also spoke about more opportunities for coastal tourism and ocean technology. He said the government has taken steps in this direction, including a change in mindset, which has now made previously "no-go" areas in India's coastal waters into "go-ahead" areas, providing access to key resources beyond coastlines.

"India must achieve global leadership in green hydrogen, renewable energy and energy storage, while continuing to provide solutions to global challenges. The blue economy, too, offers immense opportunities in fisheries, coastal tourism and ocean technology, opening new pathways for India's growth," the Prime Minister said from the ramparts of the Red Fort. He said a previously "flawed" mindset had

India must achieve global leadership in green hydrogen, renewable energy and energy storage

NARENDRA MODI, PM

stopped India's exploration of the seas.

"Today, the country has to remain dependent on crude oil. This is due to our flawed thinking. You will be surprised to know that we declared 99% of our coastline as a no-go area. We ourselves had decided not to go into the ocean for exploration. This was poverty of thought. We have now opened up these areas as go-ahead areas," he said.

The Union cabinet on July 31 approved the Samudra Manthan (National Offshore Exploration) Scheme with a budget of ₹84,084 crore. The plan for fiscal year 2030 aims to boost deepwater oil and gas drilling, secure long-term energy supplies, and increase domestic fuel production.

PM Modi stressed the need for energy security, stating India was making moves in this area with a

vision for a developed India by 2047.

"Our trains are running on electricity, and our environment is benefiting. We have not stopped here. We do not want to remain behind the world. You may have heard the news recently, India has entered a new field of fuel as well. The country has started its first hydrogen-powered train... It is the world's longest and most powerful hydrogen train, and India has also made its mark in the field of hydrogen trains," he said.

Modi added that before 2014, only around 70 cities in the country had piped gas distribution. "In 12 years, we have increased this number from 70 cities to 700 cities. This is what speed and expansion look like. Before 2014, piped gas reached barely 2 to 2.2 million households. Today, work is underway to provide piped gas to nearly 17.5 million households," he said.

He said India's solar targets had picked up rapidly. "Twelve years ago, the country's solar energy capacity was only 2 GW. Just 2 GW. Today, it is 160 GW."

On August 9, the government said India's installed non-fossil capacity had crossed 300 GW, 60% of target 500 GW by 2030. This was led by over 100 GW from solar energy.

He said the legal fraternity's responsibility did not end with Independence but "simply changed its form" — from resisting colonial power to giving life to the constitutional vision of a free India. "The responsibility is to keep this constitutional promise alive, especially for those who may not otherwise have the means, or the voice, to claim it," he added.

Legal profession found its natural place in freedom movement: CJI

Utkarsh Anand

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The legal profession found its "natural place" in India's freedom movement by questioning whether colonial rule could deny liberty, equality and dignity in the name of law, Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said on Saturday, drawing a link between the role of lawyers in the freedom struggle and the continuing role of courts as a unifying space for litigants and the Bar.

Addressing the Supreme Court Bar Association's Independence Day function, the CJI said the freedom struggle challenged the legitimacy of colonial rule through political movements, petitions, public debates, and, importantly, "through the

language of law".

"This is where the legal profession found its natural place in the freedom movement," he said, adding that lawyers were trained to look beyond the existence of a rule and question whether the exercise of power was consistent with the principles that justified it.

Justice Kant also highlighted the legal profession's role in nation-building by creating a common national vocabulary in a country divided by geography, language and social differences.

"Long before India became politically united, lawyers from different parts of the country were trained within a common legal tradition," he said. Lawyers appeared before courts under the same

system and spoke a common language of "rights, representation, and equality." That role, he said, has continued after Independence. "Courts have continued to serve as a unifying space for the litigants and members of the Bar alike," the CJI said, noting that people from diverse backgrounds continue to approach courts to assert constitutional rights, challenge arbitrary action and seek equal treatment under law.

He said the legal fraternity's responsibility did not end with Independence but "simply changed its form" — from resisting colonial power to giving life to the constitutional vision of a free India. "The responsibility is to keep this constitutional promise alive, especially for those who may not otherwise have the means, or the voice, to claim it," he added.

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People gathered and participated in Independence Day celebrations at various locations across the national Capital, including Chhatrasal Stadium and India Gate, on Saturday. P.TI, ANI, VPIR KUMAR/HT



Delhi has special role in Viksit Bharat mission, says CM Gupta

Saloni Bhatia

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NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday cautioned the youth against what she termed "urban Naxalism", saying such influences posed an internal challenge to the country, and urging them to use their creativity and talent for nation-building.

Her remarks came hours after Prime Minister Narendra Modi, addressing the nation from the ramparts of Red Fort on the 80th Independence Day, said Maoist extremism was nearing its end in the country, while calling for the identification and isolation of what he described as "dimagi Naxals".

Addressing the Delhi government's Independence Day function at Chhatrasal Stadium, Gupta said the youth constitute the country's "Amrit generation" and can question, innovate, and compete globally. She urged them to move beyond social media and turn their ideas into start-ups, using their talent towards nation-building, she said.

Gupta said the country was fighting challenges on "two and a half fronts", with the "half front" being an internal challenge posed by those she accused of denigrating the country and its armed forces.

"I want to say to my young



CM Rekha Gupta celebrates Independence Day with students at Chhatrasal Stadium on Saturday. SHANT CHAUDHARI/HT PHOTO

friends: Do not limit your strength to social media. Use your ideas for start-ups and your creativity for innovation. Turn your questions into research, use your sensitivity for service and channel your talent towards nation-building," she said.

Viksit Bharat

On development, the chief minister said Delhi had a special responsibility as the national capital and could become a model for other states in the journey towards "Viksit Bharat".

While laying down the roadmap for her government, Gupta said the aim is to ensure that when India completes 100 years of Independence, other states in the country would like to adopt the Delhi model. "This is not a small ambition. Delhi will become a city of opportunities, not problems," Gupta said.

On infrastructure and transport, she said Delhi had deployed more than 4,500 electric buses, with a target of taking the fleet to 12,000. "Around 9,000 EV charging points have been installed,

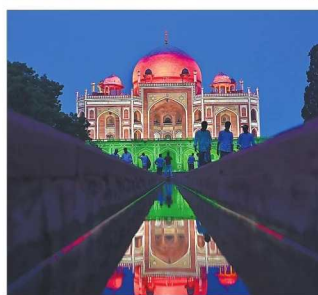
with plans to increase the number to 32,000. Three newly approved metro corridors would add around 47 km to the existing network," she said.

Gupta highlighted the government's women-centric schemes, saying more than 180,000 Pink Cards had been issued to women and transgender persons for free bus travel. She also said more than 725,000 registrations had been completed under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana.

On environment, Gupta said the government had set a target of planting seven million trees and saplings, with more than 63 million already planted. She said 75 acres had been reclaimed from garbage mountains and work was underway to clean and rejuvenate the Yamuna.

In healthcare, she said Delhi had implemented Ayushman Bharat for the first time, covering 890,000 beneficiaries, including more than 307,000 senior citizens under the Vay Vandana scheme.

Gupta said education infrastructure was being modernised, with 75 CM Shri Schools equipped, 4,000 smart classrooms prepared and smart boards installed in around 9,000 classrooms. She said the Centre's support had provided momentum to Delhi's development, with ₹2,638 crore sanctioned under SASCI for 61 projects.



(Above) Delhi LG hoists the national flag at Lok Nivas on Saturday (left and bottom) the Delhi Vidhan Sabha and Humayun's Tomb lit up to mark Independence Day. X.B. SANNIHT KHANNA/HT

'A dream come true': 5k special guests join Red Fort celebrations

Gargi Shukla

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NEW DELHI: Amid patriotic fervour, hundreds of school students, NCC cadets, volunteers, welfare scheme beneficiaries, and others gathered at the Red Fort to mark the 80th Independence Day and recite "Vande Mataram", officially played for the first time from the ramparts of the historic Mughal-era fort.

Attendees also included nearly 5,000 special guests from different walks of life - International Yoga Day volunteers, women entrepreneurs under PM Mudra Yojana, MY Bharat volunteers and beneficiaries of PMAY(U) and street vendors under PM SVANidhi.

An Army band played "Vande Mataram" while guests sang the national song, followed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi hoisting the National Flag and the recitation of the National Anthem.

A 21-gun salute by the gunners of the 1721 Field Battery (Ceremonial) was synchronised with the rendition of the National Anthem, with the indigenous 105mm Light Field Guns. The Tricolour followed a "Rashtriya Salute" and flower petals were showered as two Mi-17 helicopters, welcoming the guests.

"I came to catch a glimpse of the PM, tour the historic Red

Fort, and watch helicopters," said 8-year-old Deepak Bishnoi, pointing to the PM's striking red tie-and-dye turban. He wore a Bharat Scouts and Guides uniform adorned with tricolour accessories.

Visitors arrived at the fort early in the morning, navigating layers of barricades and security checks, prepared for rain as dark clouds gathered overhead. However, just minutes into the PM's address at 7:37am, the weather changed, and clouds gradually gave way to clear skies, transforming the atmosphere at the historic venue.

"I live very close to the Red Fort, and it rains almost every year on Independence Day. Thankfully, it didn't, and I was able to enjoy my first visit to an I-Day event without any interruptions," said 13-year-old Yash Rawat, who studies in a Daryaganj-based government school.

For Deepika Singh Singarwar, a 42-year-old lecturer at a private college in Gurugram, it was like a childhood dream come true.

"It has finally been fulfilled today. Next year, I am surely going to bring my daughter as well," she said. Udit Narayan, a 36-year-old Gurugram-based engineer working in the power sector, said being seated alongside defence personnel and just a few metres from members of Parliament felt vibrant to her.

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ONE DEAD AFTER VEHICLE FALLS INTO ARUNACHAL RIVER

ANJAM: One person died, six were injured, and three others remained missing after a Delhi-registered vehicle carrying 10 people fell into the Lohit River in Anjam district of Arunachal Pradesh, officials said.

The accident occurred at around 6 am on August 13 in the Sarti area along NH-113 on the Wanglo-Hawai road, according to the District Disaster Management Authority (DDMA), Anjam. The vehicle reportedly fell around 300 feet from the road into a deep gorge before landing in the Lohit River, where it submerged.

According to DDMA, six people, including one child, were rescued and reported injured. One female was confirmed dead, while three people remained missing.

DDMA said the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) was being requisitioned for further rescue operations as the SDRF had limited resources. ANI

TRAFFICKING RACKET BUSTED, INFANT RESCUED

NEW DELHI: A child trafficking racket has been busted with the arrest of five women and the rescue of a four-day-old infant, police said on Saturday.

Police said the accused allegedly purchased the infant from a couple belonging to the economically weaker section for ₹2-4 lakh and sold it to prospective buyers for a higher amount. Police said the gang also facilitated surrogacy through IVF and took possession of the child after delivery and sold it to a potential buyer. "Police received a tip-off about a 50-year-old woman and her associates arriving near Hanuman Mandir in Yamuna Bazar, Kashmere Gate, to sell a newborn," said DCP (North) Raja Banthia.

To nab the accused, police sent two officers posing as buyers and the five accused were subsequently arrested. Police said a case was lodged under the Juvenile Justice Act and BNS sections for child trafficking. Police said the gang had been involved in trafficking newborns for around three years. MTC

HT TWTW THE WEEK THAT WAS

Aren't you at least a little bit curious about the past week?

Some whos, a few wheres, a what or two. Take a crack at our news clues and guess away. Some answers are staring you right in the face



Rachel Lopez



The typhoon that has hit China has a fishy name. What is it? AP PHOTO/UNREDEEMED

A brand founded by Khloe's sister is launching in India. Give its name. When the Secret Service learnt of a threat to him and Air Force One at the NATO summit in Turkey in July, they acted fast. They hid him inside a catering cart and loaded him on to a military jet. Bizarre true story. But who were they saving?

New Guinness World Record alert. The largest gathering of people wearing bald caps stands at exactly 22,141. Armando Christian Pérez's fans wore them to his Hyde Park concert. He played Timber and Give Me Everything. Give his growly stage name.

Rya Bolti Public is a nationwide listening tour focusing on education reform, unemployment and institutional accountability. No electoral promises, not until a Youth Reform Charter is drafted. Which informal political party is crawling ahead?

At 93, Paul Biya is the world's oldest President. He hasn't been seen in public in two months. Investors are jittery. He leads an African nation named after the

Bio dos Camarões or Shrimp River. Not Comoros, but sounds similar. Which country?

She has played Lady Macbeth, a terrorist, a baller dancer and twins. Delhi High Court just protected her from identity misuse after AI-generated obscene content flooded Google, Meta, X and Reddit. One name; four letters. Mujhe Rang De: Who?

Crumbling classrooms, dirty loos, no clean water, a teacher who didn't know their language. So, government school students in Jaipur protested. They made no sound, raised no slogans. But they got the principal suspended. Which language was this?

Operation Safer Sagar was a part of India's 1999 war with Pakistan. It's also the subject of Netflix's most ambitious show in India. The six-part series is set in which state? The town in the Zaskar Valley, home to the Line Of Control.

A monster typhoon, with 150kmph wind speeds, has flooded parts of China and displaced nearly 10 lakh people. It's named after a marine mammal that navigates via echolocation and breathes air through a blowhole. Not porpoise, not orca. What mammal?

Special Agent Patrick Steven Yaroch used counterintelligence data to steal nearly \$1 million in crypto currency two years ago. That money was tied to Russia. So, he turned himself in last week. Name his employer, the US equivalent of the FBI.

She's a reality TV star and businesswoman. She divorced Kanye West. She attended the Ambani wedding with her sister Khloé. Her shapewear brand Skims is entering India. The answer is in this question. It's her name.

NC chief apologises to law students

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: A day after Chief Justice of India Surya Kant came down hard on the Bar Council of India (BCI) for intervening in the NALSAR University of Law students' protest, BCI chairman Manan Kumar Mishra on Saturday apologised to law students, saying he "sincerely regrets" and "apologises" if anything related to the controversy, including his words or letter, had hurt their feelings.

In an Independence Day letter addressed to "my dear young friends", Mishra said the developments of the past few days had caused "concern and anguish" among a section of students and acknowledged that their concerns deserved to be heard "with patience, sensitivity and respect".

Anything connected with the present controversy, any of my words, or letter, has hurt the feelings of our law students, I

sincerely regret and apologise for the same," Mishra said.

"There should be no hesitation in saying," An expression of regret is not a matter of prestige or ego. It is simply an acknowledgment that the feelings and concerns of our students' protest, BCI chairman Manan Kumar Mishra on Saturday apologised to law students, saying he "sincerely regrets" and "apologises" if anything related to the controversy, including his words or letter, had hurt their feelings.

The apology came a day after CJI Kant told the BCI it had "no business" interfering in the NALSAR controversy and made it clear that students had a right to protest as long as their protests remained lawful and peaceful.

The bench, headed by CJI Kant and comprising justices Jyotsna Aggarwal and V. Ramana, also restrained the BCI and all state bar councils from pursuing punitive or criminal action against students and faculty of national law universities or other universities in connection with the controversy.

The bench's reversal over the enrolment of NALSAR, Hyderabad's 2026 graduating batch,



Manan Kumar Mishra

The Council on Thursday directed all state bar councils not to enrol the students "till further orders". Hours later, it withdrew the freeze but retained an inquiry into allegations that some teachers and outsiders had instigated or misled students. On Friday, Mishra announced that proceedings against the entire 2026 batch were being closed.

In Saturday's letter, Mishra stressed that law students must remain free to form their own

views. "Our law students, particularly those studying in the National Law Universities and other leading Centres of Legal Education, are among the most informed and discerning young citizens of the country," he said. They study the Constitution, the Rule of Law, fairness and the importance of hearing all sides before reaching a conclusion and "do not require anyone to decide for them".

Mishra also defended the importance of dissent, saying peaceful disagreement, questioning and protest were "important features of a constitutional democracy" and that students "must always remain free to express their views". At the same time, he said issues could be reconsidered when further facts or clarifications emerged. "There is no inconsistency between expressing a genuine grievance and thereafter fairly considering a clarification," he said.

On the NALSAR controversy, Mishra said the decision to

attend must ultimately remain with the students. "No student should be compelled to attend, and no student should feel compelled to abstain," he said, appealing to them to decide independently after considering the matter in its entirety.

The controversy erupted after a section of NALSAR students objected to CJI Kant being invited as chief guest for their convocation. The students cited remarks made by Kant during proceedings concerning alleged police excesses during student protests in Delhi and questioned whether his invitation was consistent with NALSAR's commitment to constitutional rights, access to justice and reasoned engagement with grievances.

Mishra also appealed against allowing the controversy to acquire a "political or extraneous colour through influence" and said, "Let the students examine the merits of the case and decide for themselves. I institution respect their independence of thought," he said.

The intervention triggered a

backlash, culminating in Friday's Supreme Court hearing.

Mishra's Saturday letter sought to draw a line under the controversy, stressing reconciliation over confrontation.

"The relationship between the Judiciary, the Bar, Universities and law students is much deeper and more enduring than any temporary controversy," Mishra said, adding that differences should ultimately be resolved through "dialogue, clarification and mutual respect".

He said the BCI regarded law students as the future of the legal profession and that their "dignity, independence of thought and legitimate concerns must always be respected".

Mishra also appealed against allowing the controversy to acquire a "political or extraneous colour through influence" and said, "Let the students examine the merits of the case and decide for themselves. I institution respect their independence of thought," he said.

{ DELHI } DRAFTS NEAR COMPLETION

Sept roll out for semiconductor, drone policies

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is planning to implement its drone and semiconductor policies by next month, with the draft policies likely to be sent to chief minister Rekha Gupta for approval soon, officials said on Saturday.

Officials said the policies aim to promote new technologies and attract investment and job opportunities in the capital. According to officials, the drafts will be sent to Gupta soon, with plans to complete the approval process and roll out the policies by the end of September or mid-October.

"After approval, the policies will be put forward for public feedback and then brought before the Cabinet. Following the Cabinet approval, the policies will be sent to the L.G.," said an official.

Under the Drone Policy, the government plans to promote the use of drones and develop a dedicated ecosystem in Delhi. The policy also aims to support drone companies, start-ups, training and other related activities, officials said.

As part of this plan, the government will write to the Delhi Development Authority (DDA)

seeking land in Narela to set up a drone ecosystem, officials said.

Drones are increasingly used for several purposes, including surveillance, mapping, agriculture, delivery services, infrastructure inspection and emergency work, officials said, adding that the government believes that a dedicated ecosystem will encourage more companies and start-ups to work in the sector.

Meanwhile, the Semiconductor Policy is structured around five key pillars: semiconductor design and intellectual property development; research, development and innovation; manufacturing-enabling activities such as Assembly, Testing, Marking and Packaging (ATMP); development of ancillary industries; and talent development and skill along with strengthening of the startup and industrial ecosystem.

Officials said that the policy aims to attract companies working in similar sectors to Delhi. According to officials, the policies are part of the government's larger plan to promote technology-based industries and create employment opportunities.

The incentives under the two policies will be clear after the drafts are approved.

{ PLAN TO GHERAO CM RESIDENCE ON AUG 20 }

Jharkhand protesters seek CM's resignation

Vishal Kant

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RANCHI: The job aspirants protesting against alleged irregularities in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) examinations on Saturday announced that they would gherao chief minister Hemant Soren's official residence on August 20, demanding his resignation.

Seeking "accountability" for the irregularities, spokespersons of the "JPSC-JSC Reforms March", Pyush Singh, said: "This is the first time we are making this demand. It's time that accountability must also be fixed for the exams".

Students protesting against alleged irregularities in the examinations took out a "Triranga Yatra" on Saturday—the 22nd day of the indefinite strike started by the students.

"We have been pleading the government in a Gandhian way till now. But our demands have been ignored. We are today announcing to gherao the chief

minister residence on August 20. We are reiterating our demands to cancel JPSC-CGL exam and order CBI inquiry. If they don't, we will march to the CM's residence and keep sitting there until our demands are met," Singh told reporters.

Protesting students also demanded Centre's intervention following support from JMM-led coalition. JPSC-JSC Reforms March leader Ravindra Paswan said, "We will gherao the chief minister's residence on August 20. We seek his resignation as both the JMM and the Congress are playing politics with us. We also demand that Congress leader Rahul Gandhi withdraw support from the JMM-led coalition if the CM is not listening to us on phone." "Rahul Gandhi spoke to us on phone. But such symbolism is not enough anymore."

The protesting students have been demanding a CBI investigation on an inquiry by a panel of retired judges from outside Jharkhand and into the alleged irregularities.

Small taxpayers get a window to regularise foreign income

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NEW DELHI: Eligible small taxpayers, including young professionals and tech employees, can avail of a one-time amnesty to disclose undisclosed foreign assets and regularise their foreign income by December 31, according to a finance ministry notification.

Under the scheme, taxpayers will have to pay 30% of the market value of their assets as tax and an additional 30% in lieu of penalty. The notification gives effect to the budget announcement made by Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on February 1.

Presenting the budget, Sitharaman had proposed a foreign asset disclosure scheme for small taxpayers to help them "disclose income or assets" below a certain size.

The scheme will cover two categories of taxpayers: those who did not declare their overseas income or assets, and

those who disclosed their overseas income and paid the due tax but could not declare the asset acquired.

For the first category, the limit of undisclosed income or assets is ₹1 crore, according to the notification. Taxpayers will have to pay 30% of the fair market value of the asset as tax and another 30% as additional income tax in lieu of penalty to get immunity from prosecution.

The fair market value of the assets will be determined as of March 31, 2026, according to the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT).

For the second category, the value of the asset is capped at ₹5 crore.

For taxpayers in this category can get immunity from both penalty and prosecution by paying a fee of ₹1 lakh.

According to frequently asked questions (FAQs) issued by the CBDT on Saturday on the Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers—Disclosure Scheme (FAST-DS), "the scheme comes into force on 16th August, 2026."

A person who is currently a non-resident can also make a declaration under the scheme if they were a resident of India either in the year to which the undisclosed income relates or in the year in which the undisclosed asset was acquired.

The scheme also allows declarations from taxpayers who failed to file a return or failed to disclose the asset or income in a return filed before the scheme came into force.

ITBP DIG, DRIVER KILLED IN U.P. ROAD ACCIDENT

LUCKNOW: A Deputy Inspector General of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) and his driver were killed while his gunner and three occupants of another car were injured in a head-on collision on the Dehradun-Panchula highway near Durgam Chauri, Prayagrah district on Saturday, police said.

According to Saharanpur SP (Traffic) Shaileendra Pratap Srivastava, police received information about the accident at around 9.15 am on Saturday. The accident took place in the Sarawali police station area when the official Scorpio carrying DIG Paraminder Singh, 48, allegedly lost control and crossed into the opposite lane before colliding with a Tata Nano coming from the other direction.

District magistrate Arvind Chauhan said Singh, a native of Rupnagar in Punjab, was travelling in the Scorpio with his driver Ravi Shankar (35), Singh's gunner Jaipur, 36, and three occupants of the Swift were injured and are undergoing treatment.

Chargesheet filed in Saidulajab collapse

NEW DELHI: A chargesheet has been filed against the building owner and two builders in the Saidulajab building collapse in which six people died, police said on Saturday.

The chargesheet filed at the Saket court on Thursday named the owner of the building Karanvir Singh and builders Avinash Gupta and Manish Khatri.

Police said that, in the chargesheet, the three have been booked under sections 105 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder), 284 (negligent conduct during pulling down, repair or construction of a building), 125 (a) (causing hurt to rash or negligent act endangering human life or safety of others), 125 (b) (causing grievous hurt due to rash or negligent act endangering human life or safety of others) and 3 (5) (common intention) of Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

The building collapse on May 30 while two additional floors were under construction, burying a canteen and damaging a neighbouring coaching institute. Six people—two doctors, three engineering graduates, and the owner of an eatery—were killed. Hitting

Three 'poachers' killed in K'taka forest firing

BIDAR: Three men were killed in an exchange of fire with forest personnel in Chamarajanagar's Datti forest early Saturday. The forest department said the suspected poachers were fired first, while residents disputed the claim and sought an independent probe. Chief minister DK Shivakumar said a magisterial inquiry had been ordered. The chief minister added that guns and other material were seized.

Tear gas used on protest march to Ph Vg residence

CHANDIGARH: Police on Saturday used tear gas shells and water cannons to disperse protesters who tried to breach barricades during a march towards Punjab Governor Gulab Chand Katari's residence, seeking the release of Sikh prisoners, including Jagtar Singh Hawara, who is serving a life sentence for the assassination of the Punjab chief minister Beant Singh in 1995.

Two arrested for robbing, stabbing man in NE Delhi

NEW DELHI: Two men were arrested for allegedly robbing a 32-year-old man of his gold chain and an iPhone after stabbing him with a surgical blade in the South Vihar area of northeast Delhi, police said. The incident occurred at 12.18 am on Wednesday.

The injured, Pramod Yadav underwent surgery, said DCP (northeast) Rahul Alwal. "After being attacked by Yadav with a sharp weapon and robbed him," he added. The suspects were arrested on Friday.

Mahua raises safety concerns after told to vacate circuit house

Pragati Chawla and

Joydeep Thakur

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NEW DELHI/KOLKATA: Trinamool Congress (TMC) MP Mahua Moitra has sought Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla's intervention after alleging that the Nadia district administration asked her to vacate a circuit house in Krishnanagar constituency on Friday night, hours after she was allotted a room there.

Moitra said she checked into the circuit house around 6.15 pm after returning to her constituency following the adjournment of Parliament on August 13. She alleged that she was asked to leave around 9.47 pm and that a crowd gathered outside her premises, raising "a 'Shree Ram' slogans".

In a letter to Birla, Moitra said, "A woman MP, staying alone, being asked to vacate her right accommodation at 9.47 pm not only gravely violates her rights, but brings into question the safety and security accorded to women by the ruling dispensation."



Mahua Moitra

she wrote. "At 9.47 pm, I received a call from the district magistrate of Nadia, who informed me that I needed to vacate the premises. When I asked him the reason, he said that the 'order had come from the top', and he was only conveying the message," she wrote.

A senior official of the district administration said, "Annulment of the order of the circuit house was going. No reservation was being accepted after August 13. An order was issued relating to this on August 12. There was no intimation on the MP's arrival. She came all of a sudden. She was served tea and dinner. She was intimated about the ongoing work and was requested to

vacate. She was asked for the order which was also sent to her. We also said that we would make an alternative arrangement. She refused to vacate and stayed there."

Moitra alleged that a crowd gathered outside around 11 pm and said she feared for her safety. TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee accused the state government of intimidating Moitra under Section 26 of the Indian Penal Code.

"You cannot celebrate Nari Shakti on a stage and use the power of the State to intimidate a woman who challenges you. That is not authority. That is insecurity," he wrote on X.

Congress MP Pawan Khara said a woman MP was being forced to vacate the circuit house "while there is a baying mob waiting for her outside" and urged authorities to ensure her safety.

West Bengal minister Dilip Ghosh, however, dismissed the allegations as baseless and said Moitra and the TMC had faced opposition from locals even when they were in power.

THREE 'POACHERS' KILLED IN K'TAKA FOREST FIRING

BIDAR: Three men were killed in an exchange of fire with forest personnel in Chamarajanagar's Datti forest early Saturday.

The forest department said the suspected poachers fired first, while residents disputed the claim and sought an independent probe.

Chief minister DK Shivakumar said a magisterial inquiry had been ordered.

Speaking Monday in Bengaluru, CM Shivakumar said, "I received all the information today at around 5 am about the forest department personnel conducting an encounter with those who had gone to hunt animals. We have also ordered a magisterial inquiry. The facts will come out. The chief minister added that guns and other material were seized."

FATHER HELD FOR SEXUAL ASSAULT OF 12-YR-OLD GIRL

NEW DELHI: A 35-year-old man has been arrested for allegedly sexually assaulting and threatening his minor daughter in northeast Delhi's Harsh Vihar, police said on Saturday.

In her complaint, the 12-year-old victim allegedly told police that her father would repeatedly abuse her when her mother would go to work. Last week, when the incident took place again, she told her mother, police said.

Investigators said they took the minor for medical examination. Based on her statement and the examination, the accused was booked for sexual assault and Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (Pocso) Act, etc.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- 1 A quick grasp of music (6)
- 4 Worked in dust as one (16)
- 5 Make more records from master (7)
- 10 Not subjects one finds in taking stock (5)
- 11 Eliminate whole figure with one note (5)
- 12 Where to find one to speak (7)
- 13 Unlikely to agree but continues to cast about (7)
- 14 A show presented before the show (7)
- 20 Closes in on a marine animal (5)
- 21 One is confused in two ways by the lights (5)
- 23 Journeyed round the world perhaps (7)
- 24 Time to steer a different way (6)
- 25 A new bride's bits and pieces (6)

DOWN

- 1 Many dwell on this anagram made by setter (6)
- 7 The past of the final phase is only a beginning (5)
- 8 Gentle man (7)
- 9 A bare description is required (5)
- 6 Going out one aunt takes the back seat of a car (10)
- 7 Stop in this abode, sister (6)
- 8 He was first to show gravity of world situation (5,6)
- 14 Gets unusually close to animals (7)
- 15 Rose for soldier rising to titled rank (7)
- 16 It's full of holes yet still holds water (6)
- 17 Remarks made when on a date in Rome (6)
- 18 It may be forced to obtain a decision (5)
- 21 Moving a jug (5)

FRIDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17564)



PUZZLE 17565

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ACROSS

- 1 A large monkey (6)
- 4 Amaze by a brilliant plan (6)
- 5 Superficial wound (7)
- 10 Cause a straining pain (5)
- 11 Small narrow band (5)
- 12 Brief analysis (3-4)
- 13 Judge with hindsight (6)
- 14 Soil in progress (7)
- 20 Transient fad (5)
- 22 Perfect type (7)
- 23 Hard to catch (7)
- 24 Increase (6)
- 25 Fracas (6)

DOWN

- 1 Fundamental principles (6)
- 2 Author of poem Don Juan (5)
- 3 Constantly active (2,3,2)
- 5 Incendiaries (5)
- 6 Very enthusiastic (7)
- 7 Scope (6)
- 8 Long severe interrogation (5,6)
- 9 Cretan-born Spanish painter (2,5)
- 10 Graceless and uncultured (7)
- 11 Inclined to wander (6)
- 12 Nothing but (6)
- 19 Creek (5)
- 21 Different in character (5)

QUICK CLUES

ACROSS



DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★

GAME ZONE: Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

3RD INCIDENT IN 10 DAYS: DELHI MAN'S THROAT CUT BY CHINESE MANUHA

NEW DELHI: A 35-year-old man suffered injuries after Chinese "manuhas" (glass-coated string) of a stray kite got entangled in his neck in northeast Delhi's Majpur area on Saturday. This is the third incident in 10 days of this kind of string in 10 days. According to the police, he received information about a man named Gaurav Sharma, who had been admitted with injuries to his neck. A senior police officer said the victim was at the Majpur traffic signal on a motorcycle when the manuha cut his throat. He fell off the bike and was rushed to the hospital; he is currently out of danger.

In another incident, a 17-year-old boy suffered severe injuries after he received an electric shock while flying a kite in east Delhi's Kalyanpur area. Police said it is suspected that the kite string came in contact with the power line. He is undergoing treatment at GTB Hospital, etc.

{ IN ₹2.52L CRORE CASE }

HC quashes FIR against ex-Axis MF chief dealer

HT Correspondent

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MUMBAI: The Bombay high court on Friday quashed an FIR against Vireesh Gangaram Joshi, former chief dealer of Axis Mutual Fund, in a case alleging he misused confidential information to make illegal profits through a "front-running" racket.

The court said SEBI could not hold that the allegations were false or that Joshi was cleared of wrongdoing. It quashed the FIR on a legal ground under the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) Act, 1992. A single judge bench of Justice Ranjitsinh Raju Bhosale held that the allegations primarily concerned "front-running," an offence covered by the SEBI Act. Under Section 26, a court cannot take cognisance of an offence under the Act unless there is a complaint by SEBI or an order authorised by it. The present proceedings, which are contrary to the provisions of the SEBI Act and, more particularly, the express prohibition contained in Section 26 of the SEBI Act, would be incorrect," Justice Bhosale said while quashing the FIR.

The FIR was based on a complaint by Seelip Kumar, who alleged he suffered financial losses due to fraudulent activities by Joshi. The case alleged Joshi and four associates formed the company and used confidential, non-public information obtained as Axis Mutual Fund's chief dealer to make personal gains. The state government and ED opposed the plea, arguing there was material indicating offences under the Indian Penal Code. ED is probing the money-laundering aspect.

The court said SEBI could independently examine the allegations and act if it finds a criminal offence under its law. It also allowed Axis Mutual Fund to approach SEBI with an appropriate complaint.

ANSWERS

1. President Trump
2. Pitbull
3. CJP
4. Cameroon
5. Tal
6. Indian Sign Language
7. Kargil
8. Dolphin
9. FB
10. Kim Kardashian

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE HIGH-LOW

SUNDAY	MONDAY	TUESDAY
Cloudy with light rain or drizzle	Sunny with light rain or drizzle	Sunny with light rain or drizzle
29°C / 23°C	28°C / 22°C	29°C / 22°C

ALMANAC

Today is 16th August 2026
 1st of Ashwin, 1448
 Sun: 06:00 AM, 06:00 PM
 Moon: 06:00 AM, 06:00 PM
 Sunrise: 06:00 AM
 Sunset: 06:00 PM
 Moonset: 06:00 PM
 Moonrise: 06:00 PM
 Moon: 06:00 PM

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

City	Temp
Delhi	33°C / 25°C
Mumbai	31°C / 25°C
Kolkata	31°C / 26°C
Chennai	31°C / 27°C
Bengaluru	29°C / 27°C

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of
HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS
A quiz on the week's development.



MODI ADDRESS
becoming the second PM, after Jawaharlal Nehru, to deliver 13 consecutive Independence Day speeches.
Calling for a major expansion of manufacturing, the PM described it as a key driver of India's future economic growth. "From design to manufacturing, India must become a reliable hub in the global supply chain. For this, we will have to meet global standards on cost, quality, and scale," he added in the ceremony, which Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, did not attend.
The second stream was agriculture and food processing. "Due to FTAs, we are gaining access to a very large market; we must reach it. We must go from the farm to the export market. Our traditional cuisine, millets, spices, and fruits and flowers should become global brands," he said.
The third stream was technology and innovation. "Today is the era of AI, quantum, space, robotics, and data centers. We need to become a hub of innovation. We have proven our mettle in UP and digital public infrastructure. India has to lead in next generation communication technology," he said.
On the fourth stream, Gati Shakti, the PM said India must focus on seamless and high-speed connectivity. "Our cities must be connected through high speed rail. We must also focus on port-led development."
Defence was the fifth stream. Modi said, adding that India has to build defence manufacturing and self-reliant defence. "By developing next generation defence technology, we must move forward in the direction of becoming a global supplier," he said.
Describing the green-blue economy as the sixth stream, the PM underscored the vision for India to become a global leader in green hydrogen, renewable energy generation and storage, and deep-sea exploration. "Today, the country

has to remain dependent on crude oil; this is due to our flawed thinking. You will be surprised to know that we declared 99% of our coastline as a no-go area. We ourselves had decided not to go into the ocean for exploration. This was poverty of thought. We have now opened up these areas as go-ahead areas," he said.
Modi said India's soft power was the seventh stream, highlighting yoga, handicrafts, films, animation, gaming, digital content and the broader creative sector as key strengths.
Crowds began arriving at the Red Fort from 6am, nearly 90 minutes before the PM's address. Unlike previous years, when rain or drizzle has almost been a fixture of the ceremony, the rain ponchos provided by the defence ministry went unused. In a bid to end VIP culture and underscore water conservation, seating enclosures were named after major lakes across the country. The crowd broke into applause when "Vande Mataram" was announced. Many joined in, singing along with lyrics provided by the ministry. The crowds were equally ecstatic when Mi-17 helicopters of the IAF flew overhead and showered petals on them.
The speech comes against the backdrop of sprawling student protests that forced the resignation of then Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan. Modi made a big outreach to young people, announcing free online coaching for various examinations to help students and their families save money as these additional classes put financial burden on poor and middle-class families. He also announced 10 million young people will be trained in Artificial Intelligence (AI) in the next one year.
The competition surrounding coaching classes has become a huge burden for middle-class families. Every parent feels that if they do not send their children to a coaching centre, they are somehow falling behind or do not

belong to a respectable family. Keeping the concerns of poor and middle-class families in mind, we want to help save them the thousands of crores of rupees which they spend on coaching. Our young people should be able to stay close to their families, receive their care, and avoid placing an additional financial burden on them," Modi said.
"Therefore, we have decided to provide free online coaching for various competitive examinations for our youth. We have digital public infrastructure, and we have highly talented teachers and educators. By bringing these resources together, we will provide free coaching to the country's young people and build an entire network for this purpose," he added.
Modi also made an AI pitch. "My dear fellow citizens, when I speak of a Viskit Bharat, when I speak of advancing the nation at high speed—who is the greatest beneficiary of this? Who is the greatest driving force behind all these efforts? If there is a driving force, it is the youth of my country. It is the power of your nation's youth. The youth have an immense role to play in the journey toward a Viskit Bharat. Today, from the ramparts of the Red Fort, I wish to make an announcement for the youth of the country: We have resolved that in the coming one year, we will work to provide AI skill training to 1 crore youth, so that the youth of our nation possess the capability to lead the world in the domain of AI as well," he said.
In the speech, Modi called on all political parties to support 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, emphasising it as the call of the hour.
The appeal came months after the government's efforts to muster the two-thirds majority required for constitution amendment bills that implemented women's quota and increased the size of the Lok Sabha to 815 seats by rolling out the delimitation of constituencies

on the basis of the 2011 census.
"Reservation for women is the call of the hour. I appeal to all parties to support and take credit for it," Modi said, underscoring the need to venerate women power.
To be sure, Parliament had passed the women reservation bill or Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam in 2023, which proposed to roll out women reservation from 2024 on the basis of the ongoing census data. But the government wants to pass a new bill to implement reservation in 2029.
"Come forward to honour women and ensure that our mothers and sisters secure 33% representation in the legislative assemblies and the Lok Sabha as soon as possible. Let them contribute to shaping India's policies. You may take the credit, you may claim the accolades, but please grant our mothers and sisters their due rights," he said. Modi said the matter was stuck for 40 years due to political wrangling.
On Naxalism, he said individuals with Maoist mindset had entrenched themselves within the corridors of power in the country for decades.
"We have succeeded in eliminating armed Naxals in the forests and freeing the nation from that crisis. However, while the armed Naxals are gone, 'dimagi Naxals' are still lurking around, and those who harbour this mindset are waiting for an opportunity," he said.
They are employing various tactics to drag society down the wrong path. We must identify these 'dimagi Naxals'. We need to isolate them and align the nation's youth with the mainstream effort to transform the country into a developed nation," he said.
The PM also announced the setting up of a stronger and modern network of civil defence volunteers, saying India must be prepared to deal with challenges both within the country and across its borders.
"I announce today that we will build a vibrant civil defence net-

work in the coming days. We will familiarise them with modern systems. What measures can protect citizens from modern-day challenges? We are going to create a large modern civil defence volunteer force capable of overcoming contemporary challenges," he said.
"Making India safe is the responsibility of all of us. Whether the challenge is within the borders or outside the borders, India is prepared for every situation. Today, the nature of war is changing. There is no guarantee that war happens only at the border. Today, war can happen inside the country. They can target a refinery, the banking sector or data centre. A new form of warfare is emerging against infrastructure...but at the same time, we will have to prepare the citizens," the PM added.
KAROL BAGH REVAMP
pare a separate 'Area Improvement Plan' for walkability, cycling, public spaces and greens, backed by surveys to identify buildings of distinct architectural character or modern heritage value, and by urban design and architectural controls for regeneration.
For areas covered by the improvement plan, the draft calls for "zero tolerance towards Jhuggi Jhopri (JJ clusters), encroachment and unauthorised construction", adding that these should be removed "on priority".
The "zero tolerance" framing for JJ clusters is new to the 2041 plan. It does not specify the number of JJ clusters in the area, but mentions that surveys need to be conducted to ascertain this figure.
A Special Area is a specific development in the city. MPD designation for districts whose mixed-use character and distinct built form mean they cannot be governed by the standard zoning and development controls that apply elsewhere in the city.
MPD-2020, notified in 1990, designated the central city area—the Walled City, its extensions and Karol Bagh—as a Special Area, on the ground that its mixed-use

character and distinct development pattern placed it beyond the reach of normal planning controls. Even then, the plan conceded that implementation previous of Master Plans had produced "insubstantial" results in parts of the area, and called for regular monitoring of unintended growth.
MPD-2020 retained the designation and recorded what had changed in the two intervening decades. Karol Bagh had become a major commercial centre outside the Walled City, with commercial activity substantially displacing residential use. The plan proposed comprehensive mixed-use redevelopment, alongside parking, upgraded facilities and better utilities, and said the area's gridiron street pattern should be used to regulate and pedestrianise traffic. It required the local body to prepare a redevelopment plan within three years. Fifteen years on, none has been finalised.
The plans have not stalled for want of development. Karol Bagh's pedestrianisation was first approved by the Delhi lieutenant governor in 2009.
The Unified Traffic and Transportation Infrastructure (Planning and Engineering) Centre (UTTIPEC) cleared a detailed proposal for the following year—pedestrianising Ajmal Khan Road, creating off-street parking, and introducing a one-way circulation system on the surrounding grid. In June 2016, the Union housing ministry identified the area again for a model decongesting project and appointed knowledge partners. A 250-metre pilot was executed. Cars returned to the street soon after.
A Master Plan, notified under the Delhi Development Act, 1957, sets the framework for the city's development. It can designate a Special Area, catalogue its problems, and prescribe improvement. It cannot compel the municipal corporation to act on that prescription, cannot fund the work, and cannot enforce pedestrianisation on the ground. Each of those

steps requires separate action—by the local body, by the traffic police (which reports to the Union home ministry), and by the Delhi government.
The absence of an approved area-specific framework has been cited by planners and officials as a constraint on planned redevelopment.
"In Delhi, with every change of leadership, the projects suffer and they are not carried forward—specially true for street design projects. In Karol Bagh, the tactical part with the involvement of the community worked very well. However, that was temporary, and it needed to be realised as a design change on the road. The corporation did take up some area but the design changes and enforcement didn't reach the main Ajmal Khan road for it to be portrayed as a model street. Resolution of parking, vending and space for walking is a comprehensive urban design plan which is currently half implemented," said Anuj Malhotra, an urban planner who was previously involved with the Karol Bagh pedestrianisation plan.
ARUNACHAL RAIN FURY
Tibetan Border Police (TBP), 62 Road Construction Company (RCC) of the General Reserve Engineer Force (GREF), local volunteers and the Arunachal Pradesh Police were also moved to assist in the search operations, officials said.
"Coordinated search and rescue operations are presently underway to locate and evacuate affected personnel from the area," news agency ANI quoted the Tezpur Defence Public Relations Officer (PRO) as saying. The extent of damage to the army camp and other infrastructure in the district sharing a border with China.
Heavy rains have continued to lash the northeastern state at regular intervals since June, leading to flooding and landslides in several districts that have claimed at least seven lives and affected 153,553

people before Friday.
In a separate incident in Upper Subansiri border district on Friday, a landslide struck the Keorjaring-Bachring road cutting side, burying at least four workers—Tashi Baki, Taji Rai, Markosh Basumatari and Babul Ali—under debris, officials said. The body of Ali was later recovered and efforts were on to trace the remaining trapped men.
"Several others are still under the debris, and all are labourers. Search and rescue operations are still on. One body has been recovered so far," said Romya Marbom, DDMO of Upper Subansiri district.
Personnel from Nacho Police Station have been deployed at the site, while Fire and Emergency Services personnel are being mobilised, officials said.
CHAMOLI TUNNEL
Teams from the district administration, police, State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and other departments are coordinating the rescue operation, he said.
"Additional resources and equipment are being deployed at the site to speed up the operation," he said.
Uttarakhand State Emergency Operation Centre (SEOC) officials identified the eight deceased as Pradeep Panwar, Mukesh Singh, Durlabh Sharma, Vijay Hansda, Jitendra Kumar, Lokeshwar, Bhuvneshwar, and Devnath.
Preliminary assessments pointed to a rain-saturated aquifer that ruptured through the roof of the 3km tunnel about 1.44km from the entrance.
Rainwater from surrounding slopes had percolated into a water-bearing layer above the tunnel and released under pressure through a weak section of rock. The force was sufficient to push a column of air ahead of the water, throwing some workers towards the tunnel mouth even as others were pinned by debris deeper inside.

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REFLECTIONS

{ THE BIG PICTURE }

Can the great decline of the Parsis be stemmed?

Extinction is perhaps now guaranteed, whether via closed doors or open

I (Parsi) new year today (August 15), Navroz. India's Parsis, our fellow Zoroastrians who arrived a millennium later, celebrate theirs on March 21, the vernal equinox. At 57,264 in the 2011 Census, we could just about have filled Mumbai's DY Patil stadium. After the ongoing count, we could do so even while lying down. Our numbers have been falling by nearly 18% in every all-India tally. The projection for 2011 is 9,599, relegating the community to a "tribe".

Parsi population has shown negative growth since 1971; but even as early as 1882, the annual increase had shrunk to well under 1%. Our compromised gene pool is both the cause and result of inbreeding – and it has had an alarming impact on fertility. The Union government's 2013 'Jyoti' project aimed at stemming the decline of India's Parsi population, mainly by financing assisted reproduction. Well intentioned as it was, the initiative helped add just 550 babies in 10 years, and it is not a surprise that it had to be expanded and updated (for instance, with a new portal for beneficiaries).

Infusing fresh blood through intermarriage (Parsi marrying outside the community) could stall this precipitous demographic decline and perhaps rescue the community from a slow extinction. Already, over one in every three Parsis has a *pariaut* ('outsider') spouse; the incidence of such marriages is as high as 51% in Mumbai, as per 2024 data. But the "solution" is itself entangled in a huge controversy,

splitting families as much as the larger community, here's why.

Being Parsi is inseparable from being Zoroastrian, ethnic identity underpinned by the Navroz ceremony which inducts every Parsi-born child into the religious identity. But who can be considered 'Parsi' when only the one with the "right" parent is entitled to this vital "passport"?

Blame the 1908, yes 1908! Beaman-Davar ruling of the Bombay High Court which held that "non-Parsis" could "not be legally converted to enjoy the benefits of Parsi religious trusts, funds, and fire temples". Fair enough. But then the judges cemented patrilineal descent requirements for community membership, by confining the definition of "Parsi" to only those who had a Parsi father. The patriarchal stranglehold continues, with the steadfast rejection of later enlightenment on gender equality – all in the community whose women are arguably more liberated and compared to most of their Indian peers.

Girls are brainwashed into marrying only a Parsi. Choosing a *pariaut* has become tantamount to driving this exceptional race to extinction. Women submit (or remain silent), not for high-minded community reasons, but because disobeying extracts a huge personal, emotional price with much rancour within families and the community. Not just her children, arbitrary strictures would have turned her too into an outsider if she dared disobey. Debarred from community spaces, she would not have been able to attend even the traditional last rites of her parents. All this despite being under the safeguards of

the Special Marriages Act.

Rationally, the "outcaste" children of a Parsi-born woman and *pariaut* man are as much Parsi-Zoroastrian in spirit as the "kosher" ones with only a Parsi father, if not more so.

If preserving faith and distinctive culture is the argument, any skew should in fact favour the intermarried Parsi woman since the mother remains the more significant player in terms of bringing up the children even in the new, supposedly equity-favouring parenting paradigms. Allowed in, her children could boost the falling numbers, and be more "truly" Zoroastrian than those who are Zoroastrian in letter but not much else.

But the so-called traditionalists still talk of male "seed" vis-à-vis "mere female soil", as if the two can be mutually exclusive. Outrageously, surrogacy, suggested by some as the "only" solution, is to be allowed only with Parsi sperm. In these quarters, "progressive" is actually a hiss-word.

Much of the "dilution" paranoia centres on the huge community assets, but the long drawn-out legal battles have been for more than that. Goolchuk Gupta's is for intermarried Parsi women's rights to enter fire temples and towers of silence. Prochy Nuni Mehta's is for the rights of the children of her intermarried daughter, notably in the sporting activities where this whole family has excelled. Piquantly, her husband is a trustee of the city's Parsi *Panchayat*, but the properties it handles remain governed by old, exclusivist trust deeds. In 2021, Sanjay Dalal and her Shindi husband, Rishi Kishani, (who's half-Parsi, but from



Bachi Karkaria



If preserving faith and distinctive culture is the argument, any skew should in fact favour the intermarried Parsi woman since the mother remains the more significant "upbringer" even in the new, supposedly equity-favouring parenting paradigms. HT ARCHIVE

MUCH OF THE "DILUTION" PARANOIA CENTRES ON THE HUGE COMMUNITY ASSETS, BUT THE LONG DRAWN-OUT LEGAL BATTLES HAVE BEEN FOR MORE HUMANE ACCESS

the "wrong" half) challenged the 1908 judgment in the Supreme Court because their son was barred from playing with his "full" Parsi friends in Mumbai's Dadar Parsi colony club.

Sadly, as the *Sabarimala* case made amply clear, however constitutionally untenable, rectifying judgments are no match for religion's traditional strangle-

hold. Lawmakers don't even want to enter that turbulent Charybdis. However, intermarriage *per se* is Catch-22, adding viable numbers but diluting identity. Extinction is perhaps now guaranteed, whether via closed doors or open.

Migration significantly depleted India's Parsi population. Can it now boost survival? Today almost an equal number of Parsis resides abroad. But, even though orthodox immigrated alongside, by the late confirmed year, 2011, in North America, 59.4% had intermarried – significantly up from 43% in 2001.

Iranian Zoroastrians, with no subcontinental history, self-identify simply as 'Jarrthostis' and often exert a moderating influence on diaspora associations – all of which, btw, have only a Z in their acronym, no P.

There's an argument that globally, Parsi, may cease to exist but Zoroastrianism will flourish. This is unthinkable in India, where our very identity began. 'Persopolis' may mean 'city of Persi', the Zoroastrian tribe from Pars, in southwest Persia. The tomb of Darius the Great in Naqsh-e Rostam, necropolis of the Achaemenid dynasty (550-330 BC), may declare, 'Parsa parsulya puthra ariya aryaachitra' (Parsi, the son of a Parsi, an Aryan, son of an Aryan). But, the universally understood, formal term refers only to the "ethno-religious community" descended from those intrepid refuge-seekers who, some 12 centuries ago, fled their ancient homeland to safeguard our 3,000-year-old Zoroastrian faith.

Bachi Karkaria is a senior journalist. The views expressed are personal

{ SUNDAY SENTIMENTS }

Karan Thapar



How Doon shapes its young students

Are school days really the best days of one's life? It would be said if that were true. In my case, it would mean that after leaving Doon at 16, my life has irreversibly deteriorated. On the other hand, we all look back on school through rose-tinted memories. And the older we get the more hallowed they become.

This is a question that has been uppermost in my mind of late. Honestly, I'm not sure why. But it's possibly because my great nephew, Faris, and his little sister, Ayla, have started school and seem to enjoy it enormously. Ayla is at her most cheerful in the morning when it's time to leave for school.

The truth is that for none of us was school an unalloyed collection of happy memories. There were also terrible times. Even if they helped us grow up, they were still painful to live through. Yet when we look back, we forget the hardship and suffering. We only recall the pranks, laughter and tri-

umphs. If at all, we remember the punishments and penalties, it's with pride at having survived them.

So what is it about Doon School that makes adults in their forties, fifties and sixties, as much as kids in their twenties, turn mushy?

To be fair, part of the answer must be the innocence and hope with which a teenager views himself and the world. He's too young to know his limitations and still unaware of the obstacles that can thwart his ambitions.

Dreams seem realisable, odds can be overcome and the world appears a fair place. In this sense, school days are truly idyllic.

What made Doon special was that each of us was treated like an individual. I never felt one of many. I was always aware of my identity, preferences and interests. I hated sport and got teased for it but no one forced me to play. I enjoyed debating and acting and was encouraged

to participate. I wrote and read but that too was accepted.

Today, I would claim the story of the Doon School Scholar's Blazer proves my point. For decades sportsmen were recognized with a coveted deep blue blazer. It made them special. Those boys who had got one were inordinately proud of their achievement. Those who had not struggled – often in vain – to qualify for this honour. But there was nothing similar for the academically inclined. They had no special distinction to set them apart. It took years of persistence for the School to admit the need for equivalent treatment.

In 1971 it did. On Founder's Day that year, colonel Simeon, the Headmaster, awarded the first Scholar's Blazer. It was thrilled to win it but what followed proved more memorable. "What sort of blazer should it be?" the headmaster asked. Was it to be a design of the whole School will follow. Do you really want to be a copy cat?

Even today, almost 50 years later, I can't believe the 10-year-old teenager to design the Scholar's Blazer. I chose a conventional double-breasted style in black. And that's how it's been ever since.

The pride of Doon is that people like

THE TRUTH IS THAT FOR NONE OF US WAS SCHOOL AN UNALLOYED COLLECTION OF HAPPY JOYOUS MOMENTS. THERE WERE ALSO TERRIBLE TIMES. EVEN IF THEY HELPED US GROW UP, THEY WERE STILL PAINFUL TO LIVE THROUGH. YET WHEN WE LOOK BACK, WE FORGET THE HARSHNESS AND SUFFERING

Simeon are not unique. My housemaster, Gurdial Singh, my maths master, Sheel Vohra, my geography tutor, Charlie Kandhari, the head of history, Zeek's Sinha, and many others, whose faces I can vividly remember and whose voices I will never forget, shaped my life. Not simply by telling me what to do but by encouraging me to do it my way. And when I got it wrong – as I often did – they explained that a mistake is not a crime. It's better to try and fail than never try at all.

That's the best lesson Doon taught me.

Karan Thapar is the author of *Devil's Advocate: The Unlucky Story*. The views expressed are personal

{ ANOTHER DAY }

Namita Bhandare



Tales of 'brilliant' men, and 'perfect victims'

Quite time: Name the crime in which the accused man, even after conviction, continues to be platformed, celebrated, and rehabilitated. You will see him at literature festivals, surrounded by a gaggle of wide-eyed admirers. He will routinely appear on television debates expounding on weighty matters, an election result here or economic policy there.

When he writes a book about his time in jail before an obliging high court judge acquitted him, his liberal pals will heap fulsome praise through reviews and back page blurbs. Oh, but he has been acquitted by a court of law, they say.

We are told constantly, that the accused or convicted man is 'brilliant'; that he has an aura of creative edginess that makes some of his behaviour, well, unusual. And, yes, if that behaviour extends to young women at work, many of whom who are sexually autonomous anyway, then what's the harm in feeding the great man a big appetite? Why make a fuss because he didn't believe a woman's no?

When that woman seeks accountability, as is her right, the defence of this man will be taken up by his brood of bros. One will talk about his "sexual aura", another will write long legal pieces filled with terms such as "reasonable doubt", which will then be endorsed on social media by another political bro with massive following.

What we never see is the woman's trauma. The law protects her identity and rape trials are mostly in camera. So we never see the common intimidation tactics of defence lawyers. The titillating and giggling by juniors when she replies to a question.

If the judge permits it, then everything is up for questioning. Her clothes, her nag and her present sexual activity, her views on consensual sex, whether she smokes or

drinks. Much of this invasive, irrelevant line of questioning will then find space in judgments that are open and accessible for all to read.

Thirteen years ago, public anger over an egregious crime that everybody, for once, agreed was an egregious crime shook the government enough to make statutory amendments to the rape and sexual violence law. It expanded the definition of rape to include non-consensual digital penetration into any of a woman's orifices. It brought in mandatory prison terms that went all the way up to the life-sentence. But, points out senior advocate Vrinda Grover, this was the state's masculine response to public anger. Feminists only asked for harsher or longer prison sentences.

Those now wringing their hands for the conviction of erstwhile Telhela editor Tarun Tejpal for rape and his sentence of 10 years in jail for a two-minute crime "should remember one thing: the woman's life has been irrevocably altered for those two minutes that she did not initiate or consent to."

The Bombay High Court judgment is a remarkable piece of legislation that rejects the notion of a "perfect victim" and should become a template on how to adjudicate on rape cases. Yes, Tejpal has a legal right to appeal his conviction. But that right is already accompanied by the drumbeat of social media to establish the 'truth', not by a court of law but by a patriarchal society known to celebrate and rehabilitate sexual predators.

Quite time over, the answer is rape. But the bigger question is this: Why is it so often that women end up serving the sentence? That's for another quiz.

Namita Bhandare writes on gender. The views expressed are personal

The factory township that birthed an education hub

In the 1980s, a small company shut down, and it led to millions of students leaving their homes after Class X in search of a better future. To know why, let's go back to the 1960s. JK Synthetics, a subsidiary of the JK group, set up shop in a sleepy little hamlet of Rajasthan called Ladpur. A relatively small town on the banks of the River Chambal, it had no other factories desperately needed: power. The Chambal valley projects generated enough hydro-power to light the town. All was well.

JK started with manufacturing nylon yarn and other synthetic fibres. Indian women had just discovered synthetic sarees at the time, shiny as silk, at much lower costs. Dhirubhai Ambani had just started a clothing brand called Vimal. JK had all the important licence to manufacture. It slowly became an employer of choice. So much so that locals would say, "A job at JK is better than a government job." The company took good care of its employees – it created an excellent township in the middle of nowhere. The township was called JK Nagar.

JK Nagar followed the same philosophy as Tata Nagar: To get families to stay in the middle of nowhere, you had to ensure the entire family's needs could be fulfilled. Long distance parenting doesn't survive long, and people eventually quit and return to wherever their families were.

JK Nagar had lush houses, great roads, manicured lawns, community halls, cin-

ema, and schools. It was a neatly-cut slice of the West, served on the arid lands of Kota. Engineers came to Kota from across India. Many were graduates of the best engineering colleges in the country including the IITs. One of them was a guy named Vinod Kumar Bansal, a young graduate from IIT BHU, fairly settled in the township. Bansal would play a much larger role later.

The employees had stable families. Families lived close to each other. Engineers, managers, technicians and teachers became neighbours. The talent density was so high around the roof. People from all around the country, living together, harmoniously, learning each other's languages.

But all good things come to an end. JK Synthetics started running into trouble – no external forces, it was just some internal squabbling. Factories are funny that way. When they are doing well, it feels like they will run forever. An ecosystem develops around them. The local shops depend on the discretionary spends of the highly paid engineers. Schools depend on the rich pool of academic talent. Property prices go up every appraisal cycle. The whole town starts orbiting around one factory gate.

And then one day, the gate is shut. JK Synthetics finally downed its shutters in the early 1980s. Thousands of jobs were lost, bitter court battles ensued. Bansal faced similar adversity. Worse, he was bound to a wheelchair due to a medical issue. But he



Company townships have produced some of the best human capital in this country. They understood something very basic about urban planning. HT ARCHIVE

had a lifeline. Besides helping male JK high-quality nylon, he was great at mathematics.

He started teaching – no grand plans, just 10 students and him around his dining table in JK Nagar. His students started doing well. Word spread. What began as small-scale tutoring slowly became Bansal Classes. And the rest as they say is history, eventually creating a ₹3000-crore industry. The city already had thousands of technically educated families. It had a culture where mathematics, engineering, and technical education were considered valuable. The physical infrastructure had been built for an industrial town. The human infrastructure eventually helped create an education city. It all started when a company was just looking for cheap hydro power.

Company townships have produced some of the best human capital in this country. They understood something very basic about urban planning. People need more than apartments: schools within reach, open playgrounds, trees, markets, clinics, wide roads, places where children

can cycle without their parents being bike-ridden, and a set of people similarly educated, with similar aspirations. Most importantly, you need a community.

Many of these townships were built in the 1960s and 1970s. And somehow, 50 years later, they are still building urban neighbourhoods where you get a ₹2-crore apartment but have to drive 40 minutes to find a decent playground.

These company towns were effectively run by private-sector babus. Yet many ended up with better roads, landscaping, schools, sports facilities and civic infrastructure better than cities run by armies of government officers.

Sometimes, the most successful urban planning experiment isn't designed to create a great city. It is built to manipulate nylon. And 50 years later, it ends up helping manufacture ITIAns.

Abhishek Asthana is a tech and media entrepreneur, and tweets as @gubbarsingh. The views expressed are personal



Abhishek Asthana

{ SUNDAY LETTERS }

The need for an active parliament

This is with reference to 'Putting people at the heart of Parliament's performance' by Arun PS (Aug 09). To strengthen our democracy, there is an urgent need to make Parliament productive and participative. Equally important is creating meaningful channels for citizens to engage with Parliament.

Sanjay Chopra

Bolster hospital deliveries

This is with reference to 'Fostering safe motherhood with institutional deliveries' by Lalita Panchayat (Aug 09). Home deliveries should be stopped, and institutional deliveries should be encouraged by generating awareness among rural women. The government must ensure the availability of medical facilities to pregnant women in rural areas.

Abhilasha Gupta

Bihar's home delivery free Panchayat is an inspiration for the country and all stakeholders' involvement is key to the mother's health in the 21st century when we talk of women empowerment, this is the least we can do.

Bal Govind

Write to us at: letters@hindustantimes.com

Howknd

A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY

Kenan Orhan

Homecoming dance

His dark and surprisingly funny debut novel, *The Renovation*, has been longlisted for the Booker Prize. In it, a Turkish woman in Italy finds that contractors have turned her bathroom into a portal and prison cell. Orhan, 32, often feels torn between the US and Turkey. In America, the country of his birth, the cruelest voices are the loudest: 'and my ties with Istanbul feel increasingly precarious,' he says

Arshia

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Kenan Orhan is a man divided between hope and dismay. "There is a great disillusionment in me in the experience of being American today," says the 32-year-old, who was born in Kansas, to an American father and a mother who fled Istanbul as a young woman, amid an economic crisis and political unrest.

"My mother's family really wanted to assimilate, and became very proud of being American. As children, we were very proud too. But the America of my parents' and grandparents' generation doesn't exist," he says. "There is, for me, a great deal of disappointment. We were taught of America's exceptionalism growing up, but beyond the wealth we've allowed to be robbed from the people, and the number of bombs we've dropped on other countries, I don't think we're particularly exceptional."

Meanwhile, Orhan has been losing the ties that bound him to his mother's homeland, Turkey.

"When my two brothers and I were young, we visited relatives there every year. Istanbul became this place of infinite summer, busy streets, crowded apartments, then a place of nightclubs and fancy restaurants. It was quite the contrast to the landlocked city in Kansas we called home, where our teachers could never pronounce our names correctly, and the food we served our friends was always a little odd to them."

The visits stopped amid waves of protests, crack-downs and violence. In 2013, Orhan was 19. He hasn't been back since.

From this pain and confusion came his debut novel, *The Renovation* (2026), longlisted for the Booker Prize. In it, a Turkish woman who has fled to Italy sees her two worlds slam together, with surreal results.

Dilara is renovating a bathroom for her father, who has dementia, when she discovers the contractors have botched the job, and somehow turned the space into a cell in an Istanbul prison (complete with a bed next to the toilet and sink).

Dilara can enter the prison via the cell, interact with inmates. Speak Turkish again, and feel the ache of familiarity as she does. But also feel the very real terror that she will not be able to leave.

As the pull of the cell intensifies, she finds herself unable to tell real from unreal, freedom from captivity, home from exile.

The book isn't just a remarkable conceit, it is also surprisingly humorous.

When Dilara points out to the contractor that he has turned her bathroom into a functioning jail cell, he calls that "a rude exaggeration"; despite the fact that the bathroom now comes with its own guard.

The prison guards, meanwhile, adjust immediately to the idea of a cell that serves as a portal to Italy, taking the stand that if it exists, then clearly it is meant to. Their only response to the development is annoyance at her incessant questioning.

Her questions serve to tether the plot to reality, offering the reader a glimpse into what it can be like to live in a society that is slowly altering its nature: discourse to diatribe; logic to absurdity; freedom to authoritarianism.



The natural reaction for many people in the face of overwhelming adversity is to laugh. Humour somehow keeps you alive.

Orhan was a substitute teacher, with a side business in woodwork, when he began to write this debut novel, three years ago. It had been a decade since his last visit to Turkey. Family was dwindling there, as elders died and youngsters left. He was starting to realise he may never truly return.

Then came the turmoil of 2023. His beloved grandmother developed dementia. A national election neared in his mother's homeland. Hope rose and was crushed. President Recep Tayyip Erdogan won a third term (albeit with a far smaller margin than before).

The Atlantic reached out asking Orhan, who had by then won the O Henry award for a short story in 2019, if he would write a personal response to the poll results.

The *Renovation* grew from the short story published in that magazine. "I kept writing in Dilara's voice," he says. "It was her frustration and my frustration in one."

The humour was deliberate, he says. "Because I think the natural reaction for many people in the face of overwhelming adversity is to laugh. And I think doing otherwise is a kind of death. Humour might not keep morale high, but somehow it keeps you alive."

It's hard enough to hope, he adds, amid corruption, authoritarianism, hyper-nationalism, the climate crisis, mass surveillance, and the wholesale pillaging of the working class by billionaires. He fears the erosion of empathy, "the most important human impulse." "It takes a lot to cripple that instinct, but it is happening around the world," Orhan says.

There are those who think we can save ourselves by clinging to old beliefs; but many of these held little truth, even in the better times, he argues. "Deeply detrimental to the well-being (of any nation) is the cult-like belief that one's country is incapable of doing wrong," Orhan says.

"America has a long history of transgressions. Until we can face them, we cannot move forward." There is no one truth to any country, he adds. "No one version of the past that we can cling to and put back on like a warm blanket."



LISTEN: Postmen in Zanzibar, notes on the fossil-fuel age, a Pune police procedural: Check out the Books & Authors podcast with Manjula Narayan



1 As a person of Turkish origin in America today, "every now and then, someone makes a comment that makes me feel a step removed," says Kenan Orhan, 32. Having a Muslim mother "changes who I am to some people I know. But I was born here, so there my Americanness has never been in question, at least to me."

2 "My Turkishness is slightly different," Orhan adds. "That feels precarious to me at times because of the physical distance, the language barrier, the fact that it exists as a part of me largely in memories instead of daily life."

3 Born in Kansas, to an American father and Turkish mother, Orhan last visited Turkey when he was 19. The trips stopped amid fresh waves of protests, crackdowns and violence in 2013.

inside

LIFESTYLE

Here's to the ones who dream

What is the wildest wish you have for the world? Could the path to it come from within India? Can this be where some of the world's best new ideas come from? In an Independence Day special, Kashyap Kompella argues that some of the answers to our most audacious questions could already be here

CULTURE

Who are you calling ugly?

Lucian Freud offered a different – honest and unflinching – view of the human form, one we can now celebrate more fully, in a time of airbrushed frames. Two museums offer tribute



URBAN

Temple run: Brick edition

Bengal's terracotta temples are ancient, vulnerable, unique. A new book traces their intriguing architecture – turrets, spires, domes – and their evocative stories



wknd lifestyle

Here's to the ones who dream

What is the wildest wish you have for the world? Could the path to it come from within India? Can this be where some of the world's best new ideas come from? In an Independence Day special, Kashyap Kompella argues some of the answers to our most audacious questions could already be here: ideas such as the UPI digital payments interface, interconnected families, even the ability to live within our means. What will it take to churn out more? How could that help us take the next leap? There's more on that too

Kashyap Kompella

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It's time to think about who we want to be, as the world shape-shifts again.

We are currently makers, and doers. India supplies the world with software engineers, doctors, CEOs and blue-collar workers, films, food, a spiritual vocabulary, medicines and affordable satellites. At 79, it's time for an intellectual leap. Ask not what the world can do for India. Ask what India can imagine for the world.

Can this be the place ideas come from; and inspiration? Can we communicate those ideas so effectively that they travel the world? To answer that, it helps to be clear about what makes an idea Indian, and what makes it export-ready. An idea is not Indian simply because an Indian thought of it. A text full of wisdom is not automatically a manual for the modern world.

What should we look for? I propose four simple filters.

- **First: Origin.** Did Indian conditions actually shape the idea?
- **Second: Formulation.** Can it be stated clearly enough that someone could encapsulate and adopt it; argue for and against it?
- **Third: Performance.** Has it shown real value and quantifiable impact?
- **Fourth: Portability.** Could a country or region outside India use it without a shared history or context?

UPI for all?

If we can agree on these filters, then a map of existing ideas begins to take shape. UPI. Social security at scale. Affordable healthcare. (Admittedly all works in progress; but also schemes in operation.) Let's take UPI, because it didn't exist before India thought it up.

Today, when we travel abroad, we cannot believe how much harder it is to use digital payment gateways. Platforms do not talk to each other. Servers falter or fail. Currencies cannot be coaxed. Here at home, the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) unites a street vendor and a CEO. Any two people can swap money, no matter who they bank with or what app they choose. This wasn't a matter of technology and innovation alone. It was a matter of conviction.

India decided at the start that every payment app would have to talk to every other payment app operating in the country. It was the only way to ensure that the street vendor didn't get left out or the senior citizen, or the remote user with the nearest bank's day's bus ride away.

The shared system underneath it all, sometimes called a common rail, operates like a public street. Everyone can use it — because the government built it to be so. (Credit is due to the National Payments Corporation of India, Reserve Bank of India, and Nandan Nilekani, the architect of India's public digital infrastructure.)

The government has since done the same for documents, with DigiLocker allowing Indians everywhere access to

their government records.

This idea is all dressed up and ready to travel. Many of us have been to at least one country that could use it.

Unity without sameness

Let's pause now, and move in a whole new direction.

Infrastructure is vital, and underpins everything. But there is an idea we have — and have held on to — for centuries that could quite literally change the world.

India's most important political idea may be this: a country can stay united even when most of its people have little else in common but that idea. Many nations in the world are built on one language, story, faith or identity. Few are built on the idea that we can be many, and still be one.

Reorganisation of states by language 70 years ago did not split the country apart, as many feared it might. Instead, we revel in our differences, enjoying each other's cuisines and cultures, songs and stories. How did this happen?

The freedom movement served as a reminder, and an act of coming together: many faiths, cultures and identities marching under one demand.

Further back, our first war of independence in 1857 saw soldiers from different regions and religions rally around a Mughal, Bahadur Shah Zafar, as a shared symbol of self-rule.

The exportable idea is this: political unity does not require cultural sameness, but it does require institutions that let real differences find a fair political voice.

This matters for any country with many languages or many newcomers. It applies to many countries that were once made up of outsiders and newcomers, and have forgotten that this is so.

Families that stay together

The old joint family concept in its entirety is not the thing to export, I would argue, because it invariably rested on the forced, unacknowledged labour of women; and on unreasonable control over family members by those above them in the hierarchy.

The useful idea underneath is that we depend on each other. And have largely found ways to still do that, while making room for greater individual choice. Call it interdependence with wings. In practice this means homes designed for both proximity and privacy, public support for people who care for relatives, legal protection for those whose dependence makes them weak.

This too is an idea primed for export, as aging populations around the world struggle with loneliness, and sandwiched adults juggle childcare and eldercare. As India modernises, without fully surrendering to the nuclear family, perhaps

countries struggling to navigate aging populations and slowing growth might admit that leaving home as a college student and barely looking back is not the only way to give youth its space.

Living within one's means

India has a rich language of restraint, repair, and enough. Indians tend to live within their means; save; help families and communities in times of financial need; and aim to be free of debt at least halfway through their careers (rather than a few months after their death).

We tend to build prosperity around ideas of durable goods, shared services, lower waste.

How would this fit into the economies of countries that rely very differently on consumer spending and high levels of debt? That is an argument to be made. But the idea is ready for export — and it's an idea the world dearly needs.

The missing workshop

What's an idea we can work on next? I'd say: the machinery that turns ideas and experiments into models worthy of emulation.

A teacher invents a method for a mixed classroom. A women's group builds a reliable way to lend and repay. A man builds an artificial glacier; a woman runs a mobile health clinic. The formulas work, but often go unnoticed, undocumented. India produces experiments faster than it produces explanations of them.

No one is deputised to seek them out, criticise, translate and scale them.

We aren't alone in this. Most cultures underinvest in the dull work of writing up each experiment, testing it over and over, carrying it across contexts. Humanity tends to reward the grand, visible mission over the excellence of routine institutions.

Universities, journals, translators and honest critics are the missing workshop.

We haven't figured out the currency and calculus of intellectual property, which is the lifeblood of the modern economy.

Doing the math

This means we are losing ideas that could redraw our own future.

Somewhere out there could be new ways forward on recycling, groundwater recharge, the future of food. The next UPI.

This is a tragic loss, because we are far from done. Our women are still too burdened, caste continues to rear its head and hold us all back. We have millions of struggling poor and seniors, differently abled and marginalised.

There is so much to be done that, drawing inspiration from Rabindranath Tagore's Nobel Prize-winning Gitanjali (1910), I pray:

Where an idea is shaped by our soil, yet ready for any land; where what we offer can be argued, tested, and still stand;

where we neither boast of wisdom unproven, nor bury the wisdom we hold — into that heaven of honest thought, may our country awake.

(Kashyap Kompella is a CFA charterholder, tech industry analyst and author of three books on AI)

[A GIANT JIGSAW]

The path to 'Inevitable India'

Kashyap Kompella

I first heard the phrase in a speech by Navneet Munot of HDFC Mutual Funds. He used "Inevitable India" to describe a country that draws in capital, talent and enterprise so naturally, that its long rise seems hard to stop.

The phrase captures something real, and it stayed with me. It also carries a quiet danger that is worth taking seriously. The danger is that we will treat a likely outcome as a settled one.

To begin with, let's separate three claims that often get bundled together in talk of the country's future. First, that India will account for a larger share of the world economy. Second, it will become a more powerful state. Third, that ordinary Indians will become largely prosperous and secure.

The first claim looks increasingly likely. The second is probable, but contingent on certain choices. The third is not a "risky" with destiny" at all. It is a problem of execution, which means it depends on whether India's institutions do their jobs well, day after day, even when no one's watching.

A dramatic infrastructure project such as the Bengaluru airport's new Terminal 2 illustrates the gap. Inside, everything works.

The glass is clean, the luggage arrives, the aesthetic is pleasing. Outside, the taxi mess is chaotic war. Both are the real India.

The airport proves that the country can pour money, technology and attention into a bounded project and make it shine. The chaotic road (encroached by shanties and hawkers, poorly maintained, perhaps flooded depending on time of year) shows how we still fail at harnessing overlapping agencies and holding them accountable over time.

A deadline, not a gift

The way our "demographic dividend" is playing out offers a prime example of the effects of this — and the

risks of assuming that an outcome is inevitable.

We knew that the opportunity presented by the country's incredibly young population came with a deadline, and with key asks. These young people had to be educated and gainfully employed, if they were to shift a massive economy into a new gear, and build an economic base that a later, aging India could count on.

How have we fared on this front?

The share of educated young people among the jobless has risen steadily. The India Employment Report 2024, released by the independent Institute for Human Development and the UN's International Labour Organization, found that young people (those under 29) made up nearly 83% of the unemployed.

The figures do not reflect underemployment: the graduate who cannot find a job in the livelihood of his choosing, and sits behind the counter at the family's shop, drives a taxi or delivers food via an app. All work is important, but not all of it raises skill levels, offers income growth, or is steady enough to plan a life around.

Mixed signals

A growing economy isn't enough.

This economy has grown fast in recent decades, but never fast enough, or in the right shape, to match the pace at which young Indians were graduating. Only about one in five workers is in formal, salaried employment.

According to the government's Economic Survey 2025-26, the gig workforce grew from 7.7 million in 2021 to 12 million by 2025.

India's size makes every small gain look enormous, and it makes the unfinished work easy to miss.

Turn to the story on trust, alongside, for a bit on why we miss what we miss, and what it might take to change that.

Meanwhile...

Much of the battle for India's future will be won or lost in the cities.

That is simply how our economy is structured. Cities are where the most well-paid jobs are. They are the prime drivers of the economy.

So it says something that our cities, rather than moving into the future, have become denser, more expensive and less livable. Long commutes, costly housing, polluted air, flooded streets, water shortages...

This is where two kinds of institutional ability in India dramatically part ways.

The country has strong mission capacity, meaning that when it reaches for a big, valuable, high-priority goal — an election, a space launch, a universal payments system — it meets it.

Routine capacity is less glamorous, and there simply isn't enough focus on improvement here.

Routine capacity would mean the government school teaches effectively, the clinic has medicines (and doctors), the municipal drain is cleared before each monsoon.

Mission control

Jobs, schools, courts, health, and water look like separate problems.

They meet at one point: state capacity, which is the ability to gather good data, assign responsibility, monitor performance, coordinate, act, fix mistakes and learn. In an uninterrupted cycle.

This is where the graduate should be finding work. This is where we aren't looking, and need to.

Inevitability is a risky mood, because it turns unfinished work into lost opportunity. Gloom is just as lazy. The country has repeatedly broken through barriers that looked impossible to breach. What India deserves is the humble acknowledgement that governance capacity is not inherited, it is built with resolve. A mission succeeds through intense focus.

State succeeds when ordinary competence steps where remarkable. That's how we get to Inevitable India.



[NETWORK ISSUES]

Who we trust, who we don't, why it matters

Kashyap Kompella

In India, a family will hand over house keys to a newly hired domestic worker and, on the same day, refuse to let a census official into the house because they don't trust their ID.

We check with three relatives before picking a new doctor or repair service, before engaging with a new government process (such as the special intensive revision of the electoral rolls).

India is often called a low-trust society. But look at our lives closely, and the label doesn't fit. Indians lend money without paperwork, leave children with neighbours, trust a maid because the neighbour does. Trust is not missing. It is uneven.

The wrong barometer

Part of the confusion comes from how it is measured. Generalised trust is confidence in a complete stranger. Particularised trust is confidence in family, friends and known groups. Institutional trust is confidence that organisations and rules will act fairly and competently.

India tends to be unusually high on the second kind and low on the first.

In formal surveys measuring generalised trust, our scores tend to hover around 35%.

Tangible faith

This highlights two things: Bonds with certain formal systems are weak, and personal networks absorb part of the shock.

A bank asks for documents, collateral, credit history. A family relies on memory, obligation, affection, and shame. Call this social collateral. It can rescue a household but it can also trap one. A relative who lends without paperwork may remember the debt for 20 years, and help can arrive with strings attached. But it isn't a question of which option one prefers.

The lack of trust in institutions has immense ramifications for an economy this size. Yes, the loan from a friend or relative is interest-free, but one is less likely to access it. It is usually distress that causes one to reach out to a relative or friend—not ambition, a dream or an idea.

Person over process
The element of risk this introduces is visible across the board. Most Indians don't have insurance for their houses or businesses; it is only in recent years that some have begun to embrace private health insurance. Elsewhere, the police and courts are considered a resource of last resort.

When trouble strikes, we don't turn to processes, we turn to people. And that works. Because the system is broken in some parts, and unpredictable in others.

Man on the inside
Indian institutions often become trustworthy one employee at a time. This leads to a hard puzzle called the broker problem. A helpful councillor or MLA can help a widow get her pension, fix a migrant's documents, and get a civic complaint registered.

Have they solved the problem? No. They have made it temporarily bearable.

In doing so, a helpful broker—whether efficient government official, helpful MLA, cousin, uncle or neighbour—reduces suffering but also quietly eases the pressure to repair the system itself.

The proper path is citizen, rule, institution, outcome. The real path is often citizen, broker, official, favour, outcome.

When rights are treated as favours, the loop of mistrust is reinforced.

And a public institution that the public doesn't trust is two things: it is failing, and it is impeding growth. Countries that evolve into superpowers tend to be defined by greater transparency in public-facing institutions; and by public-facing institutions that serve as the first helping hand.

The smoothness of such operation eases business, living, growth, order—often in a loop.

Widening the circle
So, informal trust should neither be worshipped nor thrown away. Families and communities provide care and quick help that formal systems cannot fully match.

This is our strength in India. We can see how parts of the developed world are worse off for not having it.

But informal trust is also an inequality machine. Its benefits are unevenly distributed. Trustworthy institutions, instead, can aim for uniformity of access, promote confidence and accountability, as well as efficiency and rule of law.

The truth is, as Indians, we know whom to trust. The task is to widen that circle, so that a stranger in an official role becomes as reliable as a second cousin.

We aren't the only country where communities are still stronger than institutions. But we should aim to work our way off that list.



READ: The economics of exclusion: How far have we come on caste?

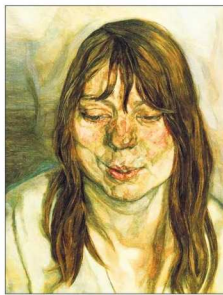
ILLUSTRATION: RAVI SHANKAR

culture

Who are you calling ugly?

Lucian Freud offered a different—honest and unflinching—view of the human form, one we can now celebrate more fully, in a time of airbrushed frames. Two museums offer tribute

(Right) Freud's portrait of Queen Elizabeth II (2001); and Woman Smiling (1959), modelled on artist Suzy Boyt. WORMEDIA



For a man who painted the human body in such visceral detail—nude, overweight, sagging skin, awkward poses—Lucian Freud's Self-Portrait with Hyacinth in Pot, painted in 1947-48, cuts a rather handsome figure.

The sketch is a flat two-dimensional view of the 25-year-old artist. His coat and hair are remarkably well-detailed, as are the hyacinths. If his paintings present us with what can only be described as the essential ugliness of the human form, this work lends no hint of it. In Freud's universe, this man—he, himself—is remarkably plain.

Contrast this with Freud's later etchings, like Solicitor's Head (2003), completed at age 80, eight years before his death. The woman lying on a pillow looks soul-tired. Her skin bunches up near her collar. (Scan the code below to see this and other works by Freud.)

Born in Berlin in 1922 to Jewish architect Ernst I. Freud (son of Sigmund Freud), Lucian fled Germany with his family in 1933 and settled in London. A trained artist, his initial works were landscapes and still lifes, and he attained a great deal of critical acclaim from the start of his career.

"When Lucian Freud first appeared on the London art scene during the second world war, he and his work were met by journalistic hyperbole," art historian Andrew Wilson writes, in a note to an upcoming lecture on the artist at the Louisiana Museum of Modern Art, Denmark. "Despite the later stylistic shifts in his painting, Freud's mythically conceived personality was thus largely fixed already by the end of the 1940s."

The lecture, later this month, is part of a summer exhibition on display at the Louisiana, organised in collaboration with the National Portrait Gallery, London (which first hosted the show from February to May).

Gross benefit
Freud is part of a transhistorical assembly of painters who have zoomed in on an essential "ugliness" in the human condition.

To him, everyone was ugly, and this was intriguing. In 1958-59, he even began to use a

hog's-hair paintbrush, which was coarser and added lines and depth to the faces he rendered. We see this in Woman Smiling, modelled on artist Suzy Boyt, for instance.

His canvases often depicted people from his inner circle: wives Kitty Garman (an artist) and Caroline Blackwood (a writer); artist-friends Francis Bacon and Leigh Bowery; many of his children (the formally acknowledged 14). He also painted celebrities and public figures, from Queen Elizabeth II to supermodel Kate Moss.

Four weeks from the 1990s, depicting phased artist model Sue Tilley, a state employment agency benefits supervisor, are widely considered his masterpieces.

Benefits Supervisor Sleeping (1995) reveals Tilley in all her glory, with blotches and blemishes, wholly unidealised. The piece set a record for highest price for a work by a living artist, when it sold for \$33.6 million at a Christie's auction in 2008.

'Just as flesh does'

Not everyone felt comfortable with his methods. His daughter Rose Boyt (one of three children born of his relationship with Suzy Boyt) wrote, in Naked Portrait: A Memoir of Lucian Freud (2024), of his "sex talk" as she posed naked for a portrait, aged 18. Speaking to The Guardian, she said: "I just sniled and laughed when I should have put my hands over my ears and screamed: 'Shut up you sick fuck'."

Today, he would face far greater scrutiny, for his parenting as well as his relationships and his later works stand comparison with the great figurative painters of any period," then director of the Tate Gallery Nicholas Serota said, when Freud died in 2011.

The artist understood his genius in his lifetime. A few years before his death, he told art curator and academic Michael Auping, "As far as I am concerned the paint is the person. I want it to work for me just as flesh does."

{ DEE FOR DRAMA }

Deepanjana Pal

We're falling off our own lists

Hollywood films are setting new records at the Indian box office, storming into top 10s. We must reinvent to reclaim the big screen

Considering that he's a scrappy kid from an unglamorous part of New York City, Spider-Man has no business being so popular in India, a land of over-the-top heroes such as Dhruvanthar. The masked superhero is the quintessential little guy. He lives in Queens, is not rich, has no flashy gadgets. Even after an upgrade, his suit looks like a onesie topped off with a homemade mask. To quote Yelena Belova (Florence Pugh) in Spider-Man: Brand New Day, "This is small, baby potato stuff."

Yet, in 2002, Spider-Man (then played by Tobey Maguire) made history when it became the first Hollywood film to earn more than \$1 million in India. Subsequent films in the franchise did well too. But they're all small, baby potatoes when placed next to...

Spider-Man: Brand New Day has become the first non-Indian film to earn more than Rs 500 crore in India.



trast, the highly anticipated Hindi film Alpha, starring Alia Bhatt and Bobby Deol, earned Rs 11.0 crore on its opening day.

In its first 10 days, ...Brand New Day became the second-highest earner of 2026 in India, behind Dhruvanthar: The Revenge and ahead of Border 2. It has since become the first non-Indian film to earn more than Rs 500 crore (or about \$52 million) here.

Globally, these earnings are tiny. The film earned nearly four times as much in China alone. It is from the point of view of the producers that Hollywood's improved earnings in India become noteworthy.

Brand New Day now tops a growing list. The Odyssey has earned over Rs 200 crore (about \$21 million) and is the 10th-highest-earning film of the year so far in India.

Meanwhile, Indian films, particularly Bollywood ones, have struggled. The stupendously successful Dhruvanthar: The Revenge accounts for the bulk of Bollywood's box-office earnings in 2026. Slapstick comedy has seen a resurgence, with films such as Dhamal 4 and Bhoost Bangla raking it in too.

Yet, there is clearly more to Indian audiences than chest-thumping and slapstick. Offbeat Hollywood titles such as Obsession (about a wish for love that comes horribly true) found audiences, despite limited shows and little publicity. There is also the success of the Partition-themed Main Vaapas Aunga and the tsunami of interest in Satluj (about extrajudicial killings in the 1990s), which was controversially taken offline within days of its streaming release.

There was a time when commercial Indian cinema and Bollywood in particular were talismans against despair, offering escapism and fantasy. Now, they have become synonymous with gatekeeping and a lack of originality. It has arguably never been harder to break into one of the established film industries in India. To survive as an independent filmmaker, producer feels all-but-impossible. The net result is a roster that radiates anxiety and mediocrity.

As we ride the high of Independence Day, it's worth remembering the soft power Indian cinema has wielded when it's to be weird, wonderful, distinctive. Let's hope the big releases in coming months can give the audiences something to celebrate too.

(Write to Deepanjana Pal @deepanjana on Instagram. The views expressed are personal)

wknd urban

Temple
run:
Brick edition

Bengal's terracotta temples are ancient, vulnerable, unique. A new book traces their intriguing architecture – turrets, spires, domes – and their evocative stories

Anesha George

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Scattered across rural West Bengal are small monuments, mainly temples, mosques and tombs, made of baked earth.

They are unusual for a number of reasons.

First, they need sustained care, because plants, moss and lichen flourish in their roofs and walls. Second, they feature intricate and unusual architecture: often, a combination of domes, arches and turrets inspired by Persia; curved cornices and ornamentation; and often European motifs featuring kings, queens and poets.

Most were built between the 1400s and 1900s. But here's the third interesting thing about them: while some were commissioned by kings and zamindars, others were commissioned by laypeople – merchants, weavers, priests, doctors, lawyers, farmers, revenue collectors – and built so expertly by secretive guilds of master craftsmen that they have stood for centuries.

Researchers estimate there were once thousands of these structures. Fewer than 1,000 survive, and less than half of these (just 400, by some accounts) are maintained well enough to be considered intact.

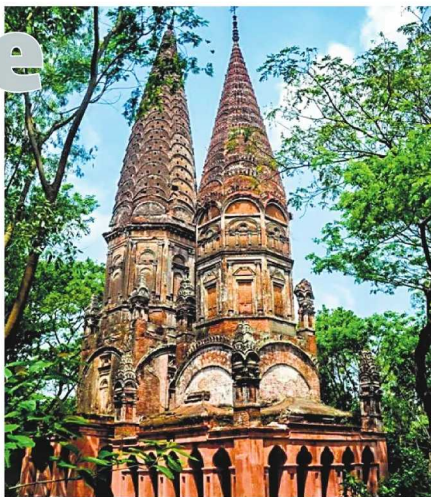
In a country of entire cityscapes of ruins dating back thousands of years, these treasures got little attention, even from the excavating British. "And yet their architecture and sculpture are unlike anything I have seen before," says Amit Guha, an independent researcher of Indian architecture, art, and iconography (who is also vice-president with a software company in London).

His book, *Tapestries in Brick* (June 2026), contains photographs and accounts from 20 years of being besotted by these structures. He has visited and documented more than 200 across West Bengal and Bangladesh. Excerpts from an interview.

What surprised you most as you studied these structures?

Well, long before modern architectural "fusion" became a trend, 17th-century Bengali sutradhars were working wonders in these temples here.

By the 18th century, they were creating towers in baked earth, culminating in the impressive 25-spire temples of the Bardhaman Rajas. By the 19th century, unusual shrines such as the twin temples of Sonarag (15 metres high; in present-day Bangladesh) began to look like they were inspired by European churches. The Chandra-



nath Shiva Temple in south Bengal has likenesses of Queen Victoria, Prince Albert, and what look like Byron and Shakespeare, carved into the brick.

How did they make their way into this visual vocabulary? Why were they added to a temple? These remain some of the many intriguing questions these buildings pose.

What do we know about the artisans?

Records indicate that, once patronage became dispersed in the 18th century, they migrated from zamindari strongholds such as Bishnupur and set up private guilds.

Around this time, we see their names appearing in temple inscriptions, as a way to advertise their services.

The guilds were highly secretive and did not document their building techniques. Researchers are still trying to understand exactly how these bricks were moulded, sculpted, fired and treated, to ensure they did not deteriorate in Bengal's difficult climate.

Isn't it strange that so many outside Bengal have never heard of these structures?

When the British first started exploring and documenting India's monuments, they were biased towards antiquity. In some ways, those biases have continued to shape our approach to heritage.

Most of the terracotta monuments of Bengal were considered too recent to be studied seriously or conserved. They began to be documented, surveyed and catalogued only from the 1960s on. Meanwhile, they were slowly disappearing.

Terracotta brick may have weathered four centuries of monsoons, but it isn't immune

When a small, forgotten rural temple crumbles, we aren't just losing a heap of old bricks. We are losing stories of pre-modern life.

AMIT GUHA, independent researcher and author of *Tapestries in Brick*



A protest in Delhi following the Nirbhaya rape case of 2012. Today's 14-year-olds were born that year. What will it take to give them a world free of such heinousness? BY ARCHIVES

What must it feel like to move through the world feeling like this? What priorities get pushed to the side: what choices are never made; and what experiences are missed out on, all because the primary concern is surviving the day unharmed?

It is worth noting that this is a group of teens in Mumbai, famously one of India's safest cities. Even here, even at 14, they know what they have to put up with in a world.

All these young women arrived at safety and freedom in the same breath. Not merely safety from violent crime, but the everyday ease of being able to walk around or sit in a park without drawing eyes, or comments, or attention of a word kind.

The safety of not having to calculate how dangerous the unwanted attention might be, and how to navigate it: leave, stay, take a bus, don't take a bus? Call dad? Pretend to make a call? Simply go home?

I had assumed my daughter and her friends would equate independence with fewer rules, more screen time, later nights. And there was some of that as well. But there too, gender played a role.

Parents call it protection. Society calls it propriety. At some point, girls learn to dis-

to neglect, pollution or well-intentioned but disastrous modern plastering.

That sounds awful.

It is. Brick structures need regular maintenance since they are affected by lichen, damp, pollution, and salt deposits. So the biggest threat they face is neglect. But the threat of a botched renovation is very real too.

Many of these temples have been painted over or paved with cement and glazed tile.

We know that sutradhars left detailed instructions for patrons on how to maintain these structures. Records show that they returned regularly for repair work. Major restorations were documented, in additional inscription panels.

Now, the only organisations with the expertise and resources to scientifically conserve and maintain these monuments at scale are the government archaeological departments in India and Bangladesh.

Would upkeep be complicated?

I have worked with village volunteer groups led by conservation experts in Ghoshpur, and the process is not as complex as one would think. Simple, regular interventions such as an annual visit to clear away plants and treat surfaces with the right chemicals can go a long way.

Tourism can be a powerful catalyst for conservation too. One of the reasons I wrote this book was to encourage more people to visit these sites. The first step towards conservation is, after all, awareness.

You also write of incredible stories hidden in the terracotta panels.

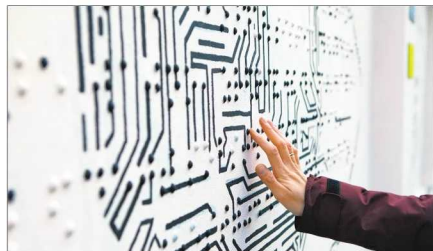
The terracotta panels feel like the 18th-century equivalent of a social media feed! There are light-hearted snapshots here of the world as it was then: soldiers saluting a zamindar; European women with their suitors; galleons, debauched Europeans, jesters, acrobats, zamindars' courts and hunting processions. All sitting alongside scenes from mythology.

When a small rural temple crumbles, we aren't just losing a heap of old bricks. We are losing stories about pre-modern life. These temples remind us that heritage doesn't have to be grand to be fascinating.

A mural in Braille at a street art festival in Russia. Technology, innovation and empathy are combining in new ways as apps and platforms reach out to the differently abled. GETTY IMAGES

{ EYES & EARS } HELP FROM EVERYWHERE

Strangers on standby: Apps that help others 'see' and 'hear'



Anesha George

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How does a deaf person direct a delivery app rider, or deal with a customer service call from their bank? How does a blind person choose the right shoes for the day?

Apps are stepping in to let volunteers connect with the differently abled, in real time, to address such daily hurdles. One has been set up by disability rights activist Rupmani Chhetri. It's a world she never dreamed she would see, let alone shape.

"Growing up in Darjeeling, I thought I was the only deaf person in the world," she says. Unable to communicate easily in school meant she often felt behind.

By Class 9, her father, a security guard, could no longer afford to keep her enrolled, and her education came to a halt.

It was only years later, after a failed marriage and a move to Delhi, that Chhetri finally learnt sign language. "It felt like I got my identity and confidence back," says the 39-year-old. "Today, no matter the situation, I know I can express my feelings instead of suppressing them, and connect instead of feeling left out."

As Chhetri finished school, graduated in sociology, and went on to work with non-profit organisations, new hurdles appeared.

"Basic tasks like visiting a hospital or making a customer-service call often depended on finding a sign language interpreter, which was usually not possible," she says.

So, inspired by such services overseas, she and entrepreneur Tarun Sarwal launched the SignAble app in Bengaluru in 2019. It offers on-demand Indian Sign Language (ISL) interpretation through video calls, drawing on a pool of about 50 full-time interpreters fluent in a total of 12 Indian languages and English.

The revenue model is simple: Each deaf user pays Rs 499 a month for unlimited calling or Rs 75 for 30 minutes of interpretation. Corporate plans for universities, hospitals and workplaces cost more, and are the main source of revenue.

Among their retail customers is software engineer Prejith Nair, 40, whose uses SignAble mainly during work meetings. "It helps me keep track of the nuances, quick exchanges and details that give the discussion its meaning," he says.

Some users are more sporadic, but just as glad to have the service.

When homemaker Bhawna Lawania, 29, in Kharar, Punjab, was three months pregnant last year, it was an interpreter on SignAble who helped explain her cramps and other symptoms to a doctor. "I knew I was being heard and understood," she says.

Hear for you

With similar apps catering to the blind, whole new avenues are opening up.

In April, visually challenged runner Clarke Reynolds ran the Brighton Marathon in the UK using smart glasses that let volunteers guide him along the track in real time.

The volunteers connected with him via the Be My Eyes app, founded in 2012 by Danish businessman Jørgen Wiberg. This app connects blind or low-vision users with volunteers through a live one-way video and two-way audio call. The latter can then answer questions such as "Which ones are my brown shoes?" and "Am I holding the phone right over the QR code?"

Be My Eyes keeps its retail service free and generates revenue by charging companies and organisations.

Among its volunteers in Mumbai is Frank D'Souza, 45, a project manager with an insurance company. "I get a few calls a month, often for things that might seem mundane to a sighted person but can be surprisingly difficult to navigate for others," he says. People have called to ask about the colour of flowers they just received. One person wanted help reading the address on a wedding invitation.

"One of the longer calls was helping someone in an Airbnb in Bengaluru navigate the apartment, locate the washing machine and figure out how to run a load of laundry," he says. "It's very humbling to realise how much we take for granted, and the difference a little help from another person can sometimes make."

On their terms

It can help to remember that the disability is often not the only barrier a person may face, says Rakesh Bhagat, 40, a quality-control analyst. "I am not very fluent in English, so the communication barrier is twofold at places like banks and hospitals."

Bhagat, who is hearing-impaired, turns to SignAble as much as 10 times a month.

Schooling his thoughts, Noida-based HR executive Vandana Goenka, 35, says the app helps protect her independence and lets her retain control of her life. "I may not want to rely on friends or relatives for every banking matter or to interpret every blood-test result. Having a stranger help out can be surprisingly freeing," she says.

There is room for more apps, more services. "This is a massive, underserved market," Chhetri points out. "There is a room for 10 companies in this space in India alone."

The deeper shift may come when institutions join in, she adds. "When a hospital or bank embeds such a service in their offerings, the accessibility burden flips from the deaf citizen to the institution, which is exactly where it belongs."

{ NATURE'S PLAYLISTS } WHY WE TOO LIKE CHIRPS & CHUCKS

On the same wavelength

Sukanya Datta

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Over 150 years ago, Charles Darwin wrote, with some astonishment, that a range of animals appeared to have "nearly the same taste for the beautiful as we have".

He was talking about plumes, feathers and, yes, sound too.

Now, a paper published in the *Journal Science*, in March, confirms that humans do indeed share a range of acoustic preferences with other animals.

The paper is the result of a study by Logan S-James, an animal communication research associate at University of Texas, Austin, alongside researchers from the universities of Melbourne, Auckland, Montreal, and Yale.

To test Darwin's idea, James and the team built a gamified online experiment played by over 4,000 participants. The task was simple: As mating calls were presented in pairs (each pair from the same species of frog, bird, cricket, fruitfly, singing mouse, etc.), participants had to pick the one they liked more.

Researchers already knew which sound the species preferred, based on previous

studies. Now, across the dataset, James's study found that humans tended to agree with the species in question, choosing the same variant of a mating call as the animals did about 54% of the time.

For instance, among tungara frogs, females prefer a more elaborate mating call, with added flourishes from acoustic whines and chucks. Humans picked such versions over simpler ones too. Across species, both animals and humans also appeared to prefer calls with acoustic flourishes such as trills, clicks and chucks.

"We had suspected there would be agreements in some cases. But we did not expect there to be an overall effect," James says. "It is somewhat peculiar that humans respond like this, given that these signals are not meant for us."

Why do we respond as the animals do? That will be part of what James studies next, along with how animals react to the sounds of other animals.

For now, one theory is that, despite the enormous diversity of life on Earth, there might be certain similarities in how various species process certain sensory information — because of similarities in the basic building blocks (perhaps the circuitry or cells or both, among other factors) that make up their systems.

As a result of these similarities, we may share fundamental perceptual or sensory biases... and therefore notice, process or share attraction to certain sounds, smells and colours," notes James, who is now a postdoctoral fellow at McGill University, Canada.

The gamified online survey was built and hosted by the citizen-science platform Music Lab (themusiclab.org), run by Yale and University of Auckland. Those interested can still play it online.

Meanwhile, isn't it intriguing to think that, when a bird starts trilling in a forest, more than one species across the ecosystem could be paying to listen?

{ LIFE HACKS }

Charles Assisi

To boldly go...

Ask teenage girls in India how they define freedom, and the answers are stark, clearly defined, and not what one would expect

A few days before Independence Day, I asked my 13-year-old daughter and her friends, all aged 13 or 14: What does freedom mean to you?

I told them they didn't have to answer right away. They could sleep on it and text me their responses. The answers started to arrive on WhatsApp, and were a bit of a punch to the gut.

"Freedom to me would be being able to dye my hair, get a lot of piercings, being able to travel the world and being able to go out without the fear of a man kidnapping me," my daughter wrote.

Nadia, her friend, also wanted "freedom to live in this country without fear." Avantiika wanted "the freedom to say my opinions without being judged."

Oshani wrote: "I wish there was freedom of not being discriminated (against) or I wish there was freedom of not being harassed."

Biah bowed a yorke: "Freedom to me would be to have control over myself to be able to do things that I want, say things I want and wear things I want without ppl questioning me on decisions that I do not affect them." That qualification stayed with me: "decisions that don't affect them."

Nyla wrote: "Freedom to me is... staying in the park after 8pm with my friends and knowing in safe, freedom to me is having the world be such a good place my parents literally have no reason to stop me from stuff (excluding drinking and all obvs)."

I think what surprised me most was my sense of surprise.

I mean, as the father of girls, I worry. I know they worry. But I wouldn't have put that worry on top of pretty much every list.



(Charles Assisi is co-founder of Founding Fuel. He can be reached on assisi@foundingfuel.com. The views expressed are personal)

WORLD

Takaichi skips controversial shrine visit
TOKYO: Japanese PM Sanae Takaichi avoided Tokyo's controversial Yasukuni Shrine, apparently to prioritise diplomatic relations with China and South Korea, as Japan on Saturday marked the 81st anniversary of its surrender in World War II. **AP**

Ukraine ramps up long-range strikes on Russian sites
KYIV: A large-scale Ukrainian attack struck industrial infrastructure in Russia's southwestern Samara region Saturday, a Russian official said. Ukraine used domestically produced Flamingo missiles to hit the site, which is 900km from the Ukrainian border. **AP**

6 dead following shootings in Michigan homes
MICHIGAN: Six persons including a suspect were found dead on Friday in Michigan, where an extensive search unfolded around two homes and a wooded area, according to police. **AP**

US says 19 million recalled eggs pose deadly risk
WASHINGTON: The US Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has said some 19m eggs that were recalled pose a reasonable risk of serious health consequences, including death. Midwest Poultry Services voluntarily recalled the eggs over potential contamination with Salmonella Enteritidis. **AFP**

Trump: Will 'soon' declare Hormuz strait US territory

AFP & Reuters
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NEW YORK: President Donald Trump said on Friday he would "finish defeating" Iran and "soon" declare the Strait of Hormuz part of US territory. Trump has repeatedly said that the key energy waterway, which Tehran effectively closed at the start of the Middle East war, is under US control — an assertion the Islamic republic denies. "After we finish defeating Iran, which is being very badly defeated — pretty soon I'll be declaring the Hormuz Strait a territory of the United States," he said with a chuckle during a political rally at a police academy in New York state.

An unnamed White House official later clarified that Trump was joking, the Wall Street Journal reported. Iran's Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi fired back on Saturday in a post on X, stressing that the "Strait of Hormuz has been Iranian, is Iranian, and will remain Iranian". Trump, together with Israel, launched a war against Iran on February 28 with Tehran retaliating by establishing de facto control over much of the Strait of Hormuz, a passageway also vital for commodity shipping.

The United States remains locked in a stalemate with Iran over the strait, with Iran denying access to much of the civilian shipping and the US Navy mounting a blockade of Iranian ports in an attempt to cripple its economy.

Taliban marks five years of rule in Afghanistan

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com
KABUL: The Taliban government celebrated five years of ruling Afghanistan on Saturday, with supporters taking to the streets, while critics decried tightening restrictions in all areas of daily life. Afghans packed into cars decorated with flags and drove around Kabul on a day that government spokesman Zabihullah Mujahid said "will be written in golden lines in the history of Afghanistan". Hundreds gathered around a square beside the former US



Vessels transit the Strait of Hormuz off Bandar Abbas, Iran. **AFP**

embassy, while fresh flowers were thrown from military helicopters over a parade of athletes that featured only men because women are banned from sport in Afghanistan. Taliban fighters took Kabul unopposed on August 15, 2021, after a lightning offensive that swept across Afghanistan, toppling government forces in the wake of the chaotic withdrawal of US-led troops. Afghans also rallied in other key cities including Kandahar, home to the supreme leader, and western Herat where stuntmen performed in the streets.

TRUMP DISMISSES CONCERNS OVER CONDITIONS ABOARD AIRCRAFT CARRIER

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump on Friday dismissed concerns about the toll on US sailors aboard the USS Abraham Lincoln, saying the aircraft carrier's more than 260-day deployment in support of the war with Iran was "not nearly long enough" even as families and lawmakers raised concerns about mental health and deteriorating conditions aboard the ship. In a brief exchange with reporters before flying to New York, Trump rejected suggestions that the deployment had gone on too long. "No, no, no. Not nearly long enough," Trump said when asked whether the carrier's eight-and-a-half months at sea was excessive. "That ship is moving right now, or very shortly, and it's being replaced with another very similar ship," Trump said. **REUTERS**



Members of the Taliban attend a rally to mark 5 years in power, outside the former US embassy in Kabul, on Saturday. **REUTERS**

47 die in Indonesia quake

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com

MAUMERE, INDONESIA: Rescuers combed through debris for survivors on Saturday after a powerful earthquake struck off Indonesia's eastern Flores island, killing at least 47 people, according to a disaster official. A second strong quake was recorded thousands of kilometers away on Sumatra island in the west of the archipelago 12 hours later, but there were no initial reports of damage or casualties there.

Rescue official Fathur Rahman said the death toll from the Flores island quake had risen to 40 by Saturday evening, with 50 people injured. Suharyanto, the head of Indonesia's national disaster mitigation agency, said earlier that people were trapped in several buildings. "These will be the initial targets of the disaster response teams," said Suharyanto, who, like many Indonesians, uses one name. Two helicopters and a plane were being readied to assist in rescue operations. European Union chief Ursula von der Leyen offered help from the bloc's Copernicus Earth observation satellites. "Europe stands ready to deploy Copernicus, our eyes in the sky, to support search and rescue efforts. Indonesia, we stand with you," she wrote on X. Dozens of houses and other buildings were damaged when the 7.7-magnitude quake hit the popular tourist island in Indonesia's east. Suharyanto said about 2,000 people had evacuated. "I have never felt an earthquake this big," Yulian Juita Ekalia, who lives in Ruteng city



Rescuers inspect a damaged building at I. Say port following an earthquake in East Nusa Tenggara province, Indonesia. **REUTERS**

more than 100 kilometres (60 miles) west of the epicentre, told AFP by telephone. "It felt like we were on a trampoline; it was really scary," said the 37-year-old university lecturer, who was jolted awake at around 5:30am (2130 GMT Friday). "As I rushed to get outside, everything in the house fell down: the television, my son's trophies, the dish racks, suitcases on top of the wardrobes. When I got outside, my son and neighbours were already there, screaming in fear."

Ex-Cambridge professor at centre of plagiarism scandal found dead

LONDON: Black academic Jason Arday, who resigned from the University of Cambridge last week following a high-profile plagiarism scandal that raised claims of racism, was found dead on Friday, the prestigious British institution confirmed. Arday, 41, was found unresponsive on Friday afternoon at an address in south London, according to the capital's Metropolitan Police Service, which did not confirm the identity of the deceased person at the time of discovery. "We are desperately saddened to hear this tragic news," Cambridge University's top administrator, Vice-Chancellor



Jason Arday **REUTERS**

Deborah Prentice, said in a brief statement. Arday's family criticised what they called a "campaign of harassment" that followed allegations about his academic work and personal life. "The campaign of misinformation was too much for Jason, who was a gentle man and who always wanted to see the best in everyone," the family said in a statement released through his publisher Simon & Schuster. The scandal erupted after some academics and media reports accused Arday, who became Cambridge's youngest black professor in 2023, of plagiarising parts of his doctoral thesis. UK Prime Minister Andy Burnham said on Saturday the death of black academic Jason Arday was "a tragedy on so many levels". **AFP & AP**

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SPORT

Harmanpreet hits brace as India ace the opening act

The 3-1 win in Pool D in Amstelveen began the quest for their first World Cup medal since the 1975 title

Rutvik Mehta
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MUMBAI: Opening matches of World Cups across any team sport can be tricky. After a period of some leeway for combination and tactical experiments to "build on to" the tournament that matters, as head coach Craig Fulton put it ahead of India's curtain-raiser, there is little room left for slip-ups.

First acts may not define the campaign, but it can set the tone. For India, that first act of the 2026 Men's Hockey World Cup against Wales was fairly positive. Against an opposition that sought crowdfunding to turn up at hockey's biggest showpiece, India dished out a relatively solid 3-1 victory in Pool D with all three goals coming from penalty corners (PC) at the Wagener Hockey Stadium in Amstelveen, Netherlands on the inaugural day.

Sternier tests than 15th-ranked Wales will await the Tokyo and Paris Games bronze medalist over the fortnight, but Saturday's display should settle any nerves that the Indian players, clad in their new saffron-coloured playing outfit, may have had.

Kit talk threatened to steer much of the pre-tournament build-up off the field, and this victory could also help bring attention back to action on the turf. Captain Harmanpreet Singh got into his elements on it, scoring twice with his dragflicks in the 11th and 43rd minute. Harmanpreet's form often mirrors India's fortunes in high-stakes



Indian captain Harmanpreet Singh converted two PCs against Wales in the Hockey World Cup in Amstelveen on Saturday.

tournaments. At the 2023 World Cup at home, India crashed out before the quarter-finals with just four goals from their off-colour leader.

That the 30-year-old got half that number one contest into the 2026 edition is a good sign. So is someone other than Harmanpreet stepping up to convert a PC, as 25-year-old Sanjay did in the 8th minute when the captain wasn't on the field. "I am very happy that one of the youngsters scored a goal, especially on dragflick," Harmanpreet told FIH after the game.

India converted three of the five PCs they earned (one went wide from Harmanpreet and the other was mis-trapped). For this team built on solid defence and counterattacks, set-pieces become important, but Fulton would perhaps have liked a field goal in his best-case scenario for the opener. And a clean sheet, which Sam Welsh ensured did not happen with a 56th-minute goal

after a melee around Indian custodian Mohith HS and the added confusion of the umpire dropping his whistle. "In our next game, we need to show more, we

need to create more chances and score some field goals as well," said Harmanpreet.

That next game on Monday is against world No.3 England, who are bound to be a tougher task than Wales. The Welshmen, though, had a different task of their own before even arriving at the World Cup. Coming through the Qualifiers in March, the Wales team requested £40,000 through a crowdfunding website. With the team only partly funded, they sought additional money for support before and during the tournament, including travel, accommodation, training camps, nutrition and equipment. By the time they took the field to play India, they had raised a little over £38,000.

As India earned their first PC halfway into the quarter and Sanjay's flick squeezed through the legs of Welsh goalkeeper Toby Reynolds-Cotterill, it opened the set-piece floodgates. Harmanpreet was all too happy to break in. Both his flicks went past the left of Reynolds-Cotterill, the second flatter and faster. India had some moments around it, like Harmanpreet Singh's long-range shot and brilliant individual defensive skills in the first quarter.

Wales got more compact in the second half, and also cashed in on India's otherwise strong defence faltering just a touch in the closing stages. All in all, though, the Indian men will take this start to a long World Cup.



**HOCKEY
WORLD CUP**
AUGUST 15 TO 30

Tejasvi blitz wins it for South Delhi Superstarz

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: Tejasvi Dahiya starred for South Delhi with a stunning unbeaten 60 off 29 balls as South Delhi Superstarz defeated New Delhi Tigers by six wickets in the Delhi Premier League at Arun Jaitley Stadium on Saturday.

South Delhi Superstarz started strong as openers Anmol Sharma (85) and Sanat Sangwan (28) provided quickfire knocks. Although Anmol was dismissed early, Ayush Badoni (35) and Pranav Pant (32) kept the 218-run chase on track with a 56-run partnership.

After Pant's dismissal, the chase was exciting as Tejasvi contributed with his well-paced innings to take his team across the finish line with two balls to spare. Pranshu Vijayran (26*) also kept his composure in the backend to support Tejasvi.

The duo stitched an unbeaten 76-run partnership off just 28



Tejasvi Dahiya.

balls to chase down the target. Divansh Rawat picked up 2/53 for Tigers.

Earlier, New Delhi Tigers produced a commanding batting display to post 217/7. The innings was built around a series of aggressive contributions and Vaibhav Rawal led the charge with a fluent 44 off 30 balls, striking five fours and two sixes.

Manish Schirawat provided the biggest acceleration, smashing 42 from just 20 deliveries

with three fours and four sixes. They were not off to the best of starts as Keshav Dalal Singh (17) and Dev Chaudhary departed in quick succession, leaving the team reeling at 24/2 in 21 overs.

Atulya Pandey (23) and Vaibhav Rawal (44) steadied the innings briefly with a 62-run partnership. Captain Himmat Singh then infused valuable momentum with 38 off 19 balls, including three fours and three sixes. Lakshay Thareja remained unbeaten on a composed 30 from 16 deliveries.

Despite Chaudhary and Hirath Shokeen being dismissed without scoring, the depth of the Tigers batting ensured their early setbacks had little impact. Laxman picked 2/40 for South Delhi.

With 217 runs on the board, New Delhi Tigers gave themselves an excellent platform to put pressure on their opponents in the chase but it proved in vain.

India a strong contender for 2036 Oly; talent hunt to identify prospects: Modi

Press Trust of India

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday said India is a strong contender to host the 2036 Olympics and to ensure that the country also has a strong presence in the mega-event, a nationwide talent hunt would be launched to identify prospects in the age group of 5 to 15.

Addressing the country from the ramparts of Red Fort on the 80th Independence Day, Modi said the government's flagship Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS), which was launched in 2014, has been a major success in providing support to athletes. "India is making space for itself in the world of sports. We

hear our national anthem frequently and see our tri-colour going up very often. TOPS has achieved great success. Whether it is Khelo India Games, University Games, Beach Games, Winter Games, or sports training, sports medicine, sports nutrition, India is moving ahead at great pace," he said.

"India's performance is improving, and we are strong contenders to become an Olympic host in 2036. We are hosting the CWG in 2030. There are about 40 disciplines in Olympics, with nearly 350 events. It is said that we don't compete in at least two third of these events because we are not even able to qualify."

"We have decided that in

2036, we should have participation in at least three fourth events. We are launching a nationwide talent hunt for children aged 5 to 15 to identify prospects in every corner of the country. They will get special training to become world class athletes," he added. The fate of India's 2036 bid is expected to be known only in 2029.

PTI had reported in January this year that plans to start a talent hunt with the 2036 Games in view were in the brainstorming stage so that the country finds its footing in disciplines like aquatics and cycling. Both these competitions offer over a 100 Olympic medals combined but none so far for India. It's an approach that China adopted for the 2008 Beijing Olympics.

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Padikkal ton hands India Day 1 honours in Galle Test

Coming in at No.3, his 131* saw India reach 288/2 at stumps on the rain-hit opening day versus Sri Lanka

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KOLKATA: A maiden, unbeaten hundred from Devdutt Padikkal gave India early control of the first Test against Sri Lanka in Galle, the visitors ending a rain-hit first day on 288/2.

Padikkal, batting on 131, reached three figures from 134 balls in an innings built less on brute force and more on a clear understanding of where Sri Lanka could be hurt. KL Rahul gave him steady company before retiring on 77 after tea because of cramp, after Yashasvi Jaiswal had looked fluent in his 37-ball 32 until his run out.

At stumps, Rishabh Pant was at the other end on 27.

It had been 19 Tests since an India No.3 scored a hundred, with 11 different batters tried in the crucial position. Padikkal's innings may have finally given India a candidate capable of holding it for a while, having been handed the spot due to Sai Sudharshan's injury.

Not only because he scored a hundred, but how the left-handed batsman achieved that. Maximising his stand, height and long lever like arms, Padikkal repeatedly went deep in the crease against spin, attacked off the back foot and used the sweep and reverse-sweep to disrupt Sri Lanka's rhythm, left-arm spinner Prabhath Jayasuriya being the chief among those at the receiving end.

Shubham Gill won the toss and elected to bat, and the decision looked increasingly sound as the day progressed. Sri Lanka's new-ball attack lacked discipline, offering too many deliveries on the pads, and too much width. India's openers settled down without having to fight through a prolonged examination.

Jaiswal looked typically positive in a bizzare fashion. He was bowler after a collision with runner Keshara Nuwantha, who had driven towards the non-striker's end trying to stop Rahul's drive to mid-on. Despite being brought down, neither Jaiswal nor India protested. That was the only wicket of the opening session, India reaching 101/0 from 27 overs.

Rahul then settled into the sort of innings that has become his trademark — patient, watchful and largely unmoved by the lure to set the tone of the game. He reached fifty from 127 balls, negotiating a surface that was



Devidutt Padikkal celebrates his century on Day 1 of the first Test against Sri Lanka in Galle on Saturday.

SCORECARD

India (1st innings)

Y Jaiswal run out	32
KL Rahul retired hurt	77
D Padikkal batting	131
S Gill c (garnage b Jayasuriya	16
R Pant batting	27
Extras (lb, nb)	5
Total (2 wickets, 73 overs)	288

Fall: 1-47, 197, 2-236

Bowling: A Fernando 10-1-28-0, L Kumara 10-1-31-0, K Nuwantha 21-0-98-0, P Jayasuriya 24-4-77-1, D de Silva 4-0-15-0, S Dinusha 4-0-17-0.

generally good to bat but gave the occasional reminder that Galle would not be entirely benign. During one passage, Jayasuriya got one to turn appreciably to fox Rahul as he played for the straight delivery.

There was aggression too. Rahul came down the pitch to lift Jayasuriya over his head for six before adding a four down the ground. Later, a cover drive off the left-arm spinner was followed by another boundary through short third. A 150-run partnership with Padikkal was completed when Rahul drilled off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha down the ground.

By tea, the Kamataka pair had transformed India's position. Padikkal's confidence was particularly striking. His back-foot game allowed him to attack spin without having to charge at every delivery, while his ability to sweep and use his feet

ensured Sri Lanka could not settle into defensive lengths.

Padikkal's recent first-class form suggest that this was not an isolated burst of form. In his last seven first-class outings before this Test, he had repeatedly conjured substantial scores into hundreds: 120 not out against Punjab, 232 against Uttarakhand and now an unbeaten 131 against Sri Lanka. He also made 142 not out in India's practice match against Sri Lanka Cricket XI in Colombo.

His progress in Galle has followed a similar pattern. Against Sri Lanka A on a previous tour, he made 67 and 94 in successive innings. This time, when the opportunity arrived at No.3 and he took it.

India scored 96 without losing a wicket in the second session, moving to 197/0. For 53 overs, Sri Lanka's bowlers couldn't find another breakthrough. There

were moments when they came close — an lbw appeal against Padikkal, a bat-pad from Rahul that fell wide of short leg and an edge from Padikkal that didn't carry to slip. Other than that India batted with conspicuous comform.

Cramp however forced Rahul to leave the field at 77 from 162 balls. He had braved a forearm cramp before tea and then returned after the interval but was unable to grip the bat and retired, bringing Gill to the crease.

His stay was brief and unusually adventurous, possibly prompted by Jayasuriya's return. India's approach against Jayasuriya appeared deliberate — take the spinner out of his comfort zone by advancing down the pitch.

Gill tried to loft him, but the ball turned just enough after he failed to get to the pitch and he

misused to be caught. Gill made 16, leaving India at 236/2. The dismissal did little to alter the broader narrative. The final session was India's most productive in terms of scoring rate, with 91 coming from only 20 overs. Padikkal's hundred was the defining contribution, but the wider significance was India's ability to control the tempo from the moment Sri Lanka quailed to exploit the new ball.

The good start notwithstanding, the most encouraging development for India may have been the emergence of a possible answer to their No.3 problem. Padikkal didn't merely survive, he made the position his own.

The next question is whether one hundred can turn into a longer run at the top of the order.

On current evidence, India may have finally found a contender.

KL Rahul, India's ideal counterweight at the top

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KOLKATA: By the time tea arrived, KL Rahul had done something that doesn't always receive enough credit in present day Test cricket — he had quietly weaponised patience. Yashasvi Jaiswal had already brought his own rhythm to the partnership, and Devdutt Padikkal had contributed in a manner more naturally aligned with the tempo of modern Indian batting.

And in keeping with his temperament, Rahul was anchoring India's batting through the first two sessions on a Galle pitch that historically behaves the best on the first day.

He absorbed the early movement and the long spells of spin, allowing the more expansive batters around him to play their games without making every attacking stroke carry the burden of holding the innings together. That is why Rahul's innings matters beyond the unfinished 77.

Rahul's first instinct was repeatedly to leave, defend and wait. When the bowlers erred, he cashed in. There was the swivel-pull off pacer Lahiru Kumara, the cover drive against left-arm spinner Prabhath Jayasuriya, and the controlled sweep and occasional charge down the pitch. But barring the unfortunate mix-up with Jaiswal that led to a run out, Rahul didn't seem to try and manufacture runs, underscoring his presence as an anchor.

The word strike-rate has acquired an almost pejorative quality in limited-overs cricket, becoming a shorthand for effectiveness. In Test cricket, however, the job description expands.

With time, Rahul, 34 and playing his 69th Test, has also adjusted to it well. The clearest evidence came in the Perth first



KL Rahul in action against Sri Lanka.

Test win in 2024 where his 77 (76 balls) in the first innings helped India negotiate a difficult opening phase before Jaiswal took over.

Rahul and Jaiswal also put together an unbeaten century stand in the second innings, with Rahul reaching his fifty from 126 balls while Jaiswal accelerated at the other end. At Brisbane, Rahul followed it with another important 84 from 139 balls, again providing India with substantial first-innings platform.

The pattern is revealing — Rahul doesn't need to dominate an innings to influence it. Like in the past, he allowed Jaiswal to be himself — inventive, aggressive, willing to attack spin as well as pace. With Padikkal too using the long levers to clear the infield easily, Rahul was happy taking calculated risks. And when the conditions demanded, Rahul quickly went into defence mode, exactly how India would have liked it.

The temptation in constructing a modern Test side is to assemble as many attacking players as possible. But aggression also works best when it's backed by an anchor. Without that, one wicket can become

two, two can become three, and suddenly an innings that looked dominant is fighting for survival. It wasn't a coincidence that India pottered down that path after Rahul had to retire due to cramp soon after tea.

Because, if anything, the dismissal of Shubham Gill came against the run of play — the India captain failing to meet the ball at its pitch but still going for it against Prabhath Jayasuriya and holding out to mid-off when Sri Lanka were desperately looking for a breakthrough. Conditions were ideal for Gill to settle in and capitalise, yet India now have Rishabh Pant at the crease.

The knowledge that Rahul is resting up for another crack at his innings must be comforting for India as he is shaping up to be the batter who makes everyone else braver.

Rahul's innings was disrupted not because Sri Lanka had solved him, but because his body intervened. He had already complained of cramp in his right forearm before tea and continued to bat with some attention. At tea, after 162 balls and 77 runs, he had done his principal job. But there is another part loading soon.

B'desh eye history as Aus fumble in Darwin

Agencies

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DARWIN: Bangladesh moved to within sight of one of the biggest wins in its test cricket history after Australia stumbled to 161/4 and remained 6/3 runs behind at stumps on Day 3 of the first Test on Saturday.

Cameron Green (43*) and Alex Carey (19*) dug in to keep Australia afloat, but the hosts face a huge task to first erase the deficit and then build a competitive total to defend in the final innings. Bangladesh needs six wickets to secure its first test victory in Australia and arguably the biggest win in its history in the format.

Resuming at 351/6, Mehidy Hasan Miraz calmly shepherd Bangladesh's tail to

another 75 runs, taking the visitors to 426 and extending their first-innings lead beyond 200 before returning to make the crucial breakthrough with the ball, removing Steve Smith late in the day.

Mehidy shared partnerships of 46 with Hasan Mahmud, 18 with Tajul Islam and then a historic 100-run partnership with Tasnim Ahmed before eventually falling for 65 from 154 balls.

Australia was at times its own enemy with another three dropped catches Saturday, including an inexplicable drop by Smith in the dead, making it five for the battered hosts across the match.

Josh Hazlewood claimed all four wickets to fall on Saturday and returned 6-89 off 28 overs for the innings.



Scottie Scheffler.

Scheffler leads after 9-under 61

MEMPHIS: Scottie Scheffler birdied the first five holes and shot a 9-under 61 to take a three-stroke lead away lead in the FedEx St. Jude Championship. The World No.1 had 11 birdies and two bogeys in the second round of the PGA Tour playoff opener as he tied the tournament course record.

Pragg draws with So; in joint second

PRAAGNANDHA: Pragganandhaa remained on course for a podium finish following a draw with Wesley So of United States in the fifth round of the Sinquefeld Cup, which is part of the Grand Chess tour. The draw has meant that Pragganandhaa remained in the joint second spot in the 10-players-9-rounds event.

PSG sign Torres from Barcelona

PARIS: Champions League titleholder PSG bolstered their star-studded attack by signing World Cup hero Ferran Torres from Barcelona on a five-year contract on Saturday.

PSG announced the signing in a statement without giving financial details.

Carlsen wins EWC for the 2nd time

MADRID: Magnus Carlsen won the grand final of the chess event at the Esports World Cup to become champion for the second time in a row in Paris on Saturday.

The world No.1 defeated 19-year-old Denis Lazavik who had beaten Hikaru Nakamura in the semifinals.

Wehrlein takes world c'ship lead

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LONDON: Porsche's Pascal Wehrlein delivered a defining performance at the ExCeL Arena, dominating Race 1 of the London E-Prix to seize the Formula E world championship lead here on Saturday.

While German Wehrlein had a perfect race at the front of the pack, a chaotic and physical midfield scrap resulted in significant post-race shakeups, most notably for Mahindra Racing's Edoardo Mortara, whose dramatic tandem ended with a race-second penalty that pushed him from fifth to seventh at the finish.

Wehrlein's drive was a masterclass in energy management, patience and tactical execution. Navigating the unique indoor-outdoor ExCeL circuit, notorious for its tricky grip transitions from the smooth indoor tarmac to the abrasive outdoor sections, the Porsche driver maximised the efficiency of his Gen3EV machine.

After strategically deploying his mandatory attack mode and pitstop boosts during the crucial middle phase of the race, Wehrlein established a commanding rhythm that the rest of the field struggled to match.

The 31-year-old's pace in clean air allowed him to dictate the tempo and fend off any challenge interrupted by multiple incidents. By taking the chequered flag, Wehrlein secured 28 points (25 for the win, three for poles), cementing his position as the title decider ahead of Sunday's

season finale. Wehrlein (69 points) is just five points ahead of Andretti's Jake Dennis, who led the championship before Saturday's race. Jaguar's Mitch Evans is still in the title fight with 148 points.

Early in the E-Prix, Mortara made contact with Lola's Zane Maloney. The incident left the Barbadian with terminal damage, forcing an early retirement and temporarily bringing out the yellow flags.

Mahindra in early hunt Mortara survived and kept his Mahindrajumps contenders. As the race reached its climax, a frantic four-way battle for fourth place erupted. Dan Ticktum, who had been running strongly, was shuffled down the order in the scrappy final laps, slipping behind Sebastian Buemi, Mortara, and Taylor Barnard.

Mortara crossed the finish line fifth. However, the stewards investigated him for a late, aggressive dive on Ticktum into the heavy braking zone at Turn 1. Following a post-race review, race control handed Mortara a five-second penalty for causing the collision, dropping the Swiss to seventh.

Behind that drama, the remaining positions were fiercely contested. Following the penalty adjustments, the top 10 was rounded out by crucial late-race incidents. The stewards shuffled order saw the likes of Evans, Nick Cassidy, and Oliver Rowland claiming vital points, assuring the teams' and drivers' championships remain mathematically alive.

Injury woes over, crowd favourites Satwik-Chirag eye home comfort

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NEW DELHI: There was a time in global badminton when watching high-adrenaline, nerve-jangling men's doubles contests made you wonder if an Indian pair could ever combine such pace, energy and skill in their game. Then came Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty and they shook the world order with their explosive style.

Some of the biggest moments in Indian badminton in recent years have been in the hunt for this sensational combination. A historic Thomas Cup triumph, Asian Games and Asian Championships gold medals in men's doubles along with two World Championships bronze medals, Satwik and Chirag have been relentless in their pursuit to staying among the best.

They are set for another big challenge as they drive India's campaign at the BWF World Championships, which begin at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium here on Monday.

This season, the duo ended a two-year wait for a BWF World Tour title with a scintillating victory at the Singapore Open in May. Unfortunately, at the Indonesia Open for the following week, Satwik's shoulder injury returned, forcing them to withdraw from the opening round.

When they returned a month later at the Japan Open (June 2-7), the shoulder trouble resurfaced. Frustrated, they had to pull out again after losing their first game 19-21, to the Danish



Satwiksairaj Rankireddy (L) and Chirag Shetty will lead India's doubles hopes.

pair of Daniel Lundgaard and Mads Vestergaard.

The Indians, coached by Malaysian Tan Kim Her, rightly decided to focus all energies on rehabilitation and getting ready for the Worlds.

It is in this backdrop that the world No.5 pair, one of the best attacking combinations in the world, enters the World Championships carrying the expectations of home fans. They would be anxious as they await their second-round opponents having

received a first round bye. "We are very excited, but we want to take one match at a time," Satwik told HT.

Satwik would be hoping that his shoulder holds well so that he can start cracking those smashers and for them to quickly get back into their best.

"I had time with the rehab. But tournaments and practice are much different. So, we have to see how I go in the tournament. Because in practice, you don't have so much pressure. In

the tournament, you need to see how it goes."

The Singapore Open title was a high point and they felt they could have carried the momentum forward but for the injury.

"Winning a major title after a gap we got the confidence back. We played some disciplined game and stuck to the game plan throughout, but it against the Koreans or the Indonesians. Even though we lost the first game (in the final) we came back to win the second and third

game. That's a good motivation for us. We know all the time that if we are fit enough to play, we can beat anyone on the given day. So, our main focus is to get back on track, get that momentum and keep going. So, we play a little bit freer."

For Satwik, 26, given his power game, shoulder issues crop up while playing back-to-back tournaments. But, guided by their coach, the duo has been managing the workload well.

"I think it's difficult for my shoulder to play four tournaments back-to-back in less than one-and-a-half months. So, somewhere we need to manage that," he says.

It could be frustrating for Chirag, but they have developed a strong bond to see through these tough challenges and stay positive.

"I think you get used to it. Yes, it's difficult, but you understand and we try to do everything possible to get back as early as possible," Chirag, 22, told HT.